

The Hours



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF MICHAEL CUNNINGHAM

Michael Cunningham was born in Ohio and grew up in Southern California. He studied English at Stanford and went on to obtain an MFA at the Iowa Writers' Workshop, where he began to publish his first short stories. While his early works received awards and critical acclaim, particularly his novel *A Home at the End of the World*, Cunningham's breakthrough novel was *The Hours* (1998), which won the Pulitzer Prize and brought his work to a wider audience. Cunningham also wrote the screenplay for 2002 film adaptation of *The Hours*, which further increased the popularity of the novel, and which led to Nicole Kidman winning a Best Actress Oscar for her portrayal of Virginia Woolf. Cunningham has continued to write stories, novels, screenplays, and nonfiction, with his most recent novel, *Day*, dealing with a family affected by the COVID-19 pandemic. He currently lectures on English literature at Yale University.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Although Cunningham takes some creative liberties with his lightly fictionalized version of Virginia Woolf in *The Hours*, the broad outlines of her life in the novel are the same as her real life. Virginia Woolf's story is bookended by the two World Wars, with her beginning to write *Mrs. Dalloway* shortly after World War I and her dying by suicide in the early years of World War II. This tumultuous time in European history helped shape the development of modernist literature, an experimental movement that tried to make sense of a changing world and in which Woolf was a key figure. Laura Brown's story takes place shortly after the end of World War II. In her story, Laura feels stifled and unfulfilled by the domestic responsibilities society expects of her. In her 1963 book *The Feminine Mystique*, feminist writer and activist Betty Friedan would later challenge the notion that women like Laura should find total fulfillment in their roles as wives and mothers. Scholars credit Friedan's book with kicking off second-wave feminism, though this wouldn't happen until over a decade after Laura's story takes place. The final story chronologically, which follows Clarissa, takes place against the backdrop of the HIV/AIDS epidemic in the United States, which began in 1981 and led to the increased stigmatization of homosexuality across the country, as the disease was particularly prominent among gay men. At the height of the epidemic, many activists accused the administration of current president Ronald Reagan of failing to act on the virus. By the 1990s, advancements in medical technology led to much better survival outcomes for people living with HIV, although this didn't help people with advanced

forms of illness (like the character Richard in *The Hours*), and the disease continues to persist as one of the most serious illnesses for certain parts of the world.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Cunningham's *The Hours* draws heavily on Virginia Woolf's *Mrs. Dalloway*, recreating some elements of the plot and theme, featuring several characters who read the novel, and even including a fictionalized version of Virginia Woolf herself, depicted in *The Hours* during the time in which she was writing the novel. *The Hours* was originally Woolf's title for an earlier draft of *Mrs. Dalloway*, and Cunningham references several other works by Woolf. Most notably, Cunningham refers to Woolf's essay in defense of modernist writing, "Mr. Bennett and Mrs. Brown" (where the last name of the character Laura Brown comes from), as well as Woolf's feminist essay *A Room of One's Own*, which is particularly relevant to the events of Laura's story, in which she rents a hotel room to have time to herself to read *Mrs. Dalloway*. Many critics consider *Mrs. Dalloway* to be Woolf's response to *Ulysses* by James Joyce (which also takes place during a single day in June). *The Hours* is one of several novels from around the turn of the millennium that reinterprets an older classic novel, including *Bridget Jones's Diary* by Helen Fielding (inspired by Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice*) and *On Beauty* by Zadie Smith (inspired by E. M. Forster's *Howards End*).

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Hours
- **When Written:** Late 1990s
- **Where Written:** New York City
- **When Published:** 1998
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel, Historical Fiction
- **Setting:** Richmond, England; Los Angeles, California; New York City
- **Climax:** Richard dies by suicide.
- **Antagonist:** Time and Mortality
- **Point of View:** Third Person Omniscient

EXTRA CREDIT

Calling His Shot. In *The Hours*, there is a brief cameo from an unknown celebrity who might be Meryl Streep or Vanessa Redgrave. Cunningham would go on to write for both actors, with Streep starring as Clarissa in the film adaptation of *The Hours* and Redgrave starring in *Evening*, a film for which

Cunningham co-wrote the screenplay.

4 beds, 0 baths. Cunningham introduces an anachronism when he references Virginia washing her face in a bathroom—in fact, her home only had an outhouse at the time. In 2022, that same house was listed for £3.5 million.



PLOT SUMMARY

One day near the beginning of World War II, Virginia Woolf leaves a note for her husband, Leonard, and sister, Vanessa. She then goes out to a river with stones in the pockets of her jacket to drown herself.

Years later, two women (Laura and Clarissa) each deal with problems in their lives similar to those that the titular character Mrs. Dalloway faces in Virginia Woolf's novel *Mrs. Dalloway*. The story shifts between three timelines, following Virginia's life in a suburb outside London in 1923 as she writes *Mrs. Dalloway*, Laura's life in Los Angeles in 1949 as she makes a **cake** for the birthday of her husband (Dan), and Clarissa's life near the turn of the millennium in New York City as she prepares a party before an awards ceremony for her friend and former lover, Richard (whose nickname for Clarissa is "Mrs. Dalloway").

Clarissa spends her morning buying **flowers** in preparation for Richard's party. Richard is a famous writer who is best known for his poetry, though he also wrote one long novel about a suicidal housewife. Many people interpret the novel as being inspired by Clarissa. Richard is about to receive an award called the Carrouthers prize, and Clarissa has organized a party beforehand. As Clarissa walks around New York City, she runs into some of her and Richard's mutual acquaintances, and she begins to think back to when she was in college and attempted a relationship with Richard while he was also in a relationship with Louis. The situation with didn't work out, and Richard and Louis spent many years together while Clarissa went on to live with a new partner named Sally, with whom she has a daughter (Julia). Now, Richard has left Louis and lives alone in declining health due to the toll that AIDS has taken on him. Clarissa serves as his primary caregiver.

Meanwhile, back in the 1920s, Virginia spends her morning writing part of *Mrs. Dalloway* before preparing for a visit from her sister, Vanessa. Virginia struggles to write much because she fears that too much exertion will bring back her painful headaches. These headaches are the reason why Virginia's husband, Leonard, insists that they must live out in the peaceful suburb of Richmond, even though Virginia longs to return to the excitement of living in London.

In 1949, Laura, pregnant with her second child, sleeps in late on the morning of Dan's birthday, exhausted from staying up late to read *Mrs. Dalloway* the night before. She wants to give Dan a

perfect birthday, so she sets to work making a cake for him with their son, Richie (Clarissa's friend Richard as a child). Making the cake with Richie seems to temporarily help Laura overcome her anxieties, but when the cake is done, she fears it isn't good enough and throws it out to start over again.

In Clarissa's timeline, Clarissa finally makes it to Richard's apartment and finds him anxious about attending the party and awards ceremony. Clarissa can tell how much Richard's mental state has been affected by his illness—he has lost much of the wit and sharpness that used to define him. She promises to come by early to help him get dressed and ready for his party.

Back in the 1920s, Virginia wants to serve her sister the best possible refreshments, so she sends her servant Nelly on a trip to London and back. But, as it turns out, Vanessa arrives earlier than expected, throwing off Virginia's plans. Leonard refuses to leave his work until the time when Vanessa originally promised to come. As Virginia is entertaining Vanessa, her children discover a dying bird outside and hold a funeral for it.

In 1949, Laura finishes a second, better cake to replace the first one she made with Richie and gets a visit from her neighbor, Kitty. Kitty reveals that she has to go to the hospital the next day to get a growth on her uterus checked out. As Laura hugs Kitty to console her, the two of them kiss on the lips, and Laura realizes how much she desires Kitty. The women pull away suddenly, and Laura becomes flustered when she realizes Richie has witnessed the intimate moment.

Soon after, Laura begins to feel like she has to leave her house. She drops off Richie with a neighbor, claiming she has to run errands. However, Laura's real intention is to find a place to read *Mrs. Dalloway* in private. Laura realizes that it's almost impossible for her to find a place that's suitably safe and private for her needs, so she eventually ends up renting a hotel room for the night, even though she only plans to use it for a couple hours. She feels like she's doing something wrong.

In Clarissa's timeline, Clarissa goes to meet Richard before his party and finds him sitting on his windowsill in a robe with one leg out the window of his fifth-story apartment. She is frightened and tries to convince Richard to come back in, but as Richard talks, he seems to be in a daze from his medication and his illness. He eventually jumps out the window, falling to his death.

In Virginia's timeline, after Vanessa leaves, Virginia begins to feel particularly restless about her life in Richmond. She decides to take a spontaneous trip into London and even goes to the train station to buy a ticket. But when she's waiting for her train to arrive, she runs into Leonard, and this convinces her not to take the train after all.

In 1949, Laura's birthday party for Dan seems to be a success, although when he's blowing out the candles, he accidentally spits on her cake. Even though Laura is relieved that the night has gone well, before she goes to bed with Dan, she looks at the

sleeping pills in her cabinet and considers how killing herself wouldn't be any more difficult than checking into the hotel was earlier that day.

Finally, the timelines intersect, with Laura, now an elderly woman, arriving at Clarissa's apartment following Clarissa's news about the death of Laura's son, Richard. The flowers that Clarissa originally bought for Richard's party now become funeral flowers. Although Richard's party is now cancelled, Clarissa, Laura, Sally, and Julia all decide to eat some of the food because it will soon go to waste. Clarissa considers how Richard's death has set her free from the Mrs. Dalloway nickname he imposed on her. She also considers the difficult hour ahead of her she must now face.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Clarissa Vaughan – Clarissa is a publisher who lives in New York City with her partner, Sally, and their daughter, Julia in the 1990s. She is good friends with Richard, a man she used to love romantically and possibly still loves. She fondly remembers a time she kissed Richard in the past and feels nostalgia for her youth, when she and Louis tried to both have a relationship with Richard at the same time. The novel follows one day in Clarissa's life as she prepares a party for Richard before the ceremony for an award he's receiving. Richard often calls Clarissa "Mrs. Dalloway" after the titular character from the Virginia Woolf novel *Mrs. Dalloway*, and Clarissa has mixed feelings about this. On the one hand, Clarissa does resemble Woolf's Mrs. Dalloway (each woman starts her day carrying out the domestic tasks of buying **flowers** and preparing for a party). But Clarissa feels that Richard often misunderstands her, particularly when he writes a long novel about a bourgeoisie housewife that many people believe is a stand-in for Clarissa. The woman in Richard's novel ultimately dies by suicide. Meanwhile, the protagonist of Woolf's novel feels repressed and unsatisfied by domestic life, though she doesn't die at the end. In *The Hours*, Clarissa resents Richard's implication that she, like these two fictional women, feels repressed and unfulfilled in the conventional, domestic life she's made for herself. Clarissa also feels judged by Julia's mentor, Mary Krull, who believes that Clarissa's relationship with Sally is a misguided attempt to try to replicate the conventions of a heterosexual marriage. Ultimately, Clarissa's party plans become irrelevant after Richard kills himself in front of Clarissa, and Clarissa and Richard's friends and loved ones (including his mother, Laura) gather in mourning rather than in celebration. In some ways, Clarissa is a reversal of Virginia Woolf's Mrs. Dalloway (who remains married to a practical, unromantic man named Richard while longing for a woman named Sally). Clarissa's life reveals how women in modern-day society continue to struggle with society's complex

(and sometimes contradictory) expectations for them, even in a comparatively more progressive, sexually liberated world.

Laura Brown – Laura Brown is an avid reader who lives in Los Angeles in 1949. She's married to Dan and has a son named Richie. Like Clarissa in the present-day timeline of *The Hours*, and like Mrs. Dalloway in Virginia Woolf's novel *Mrs. Dalloway*, Laura's timeline follows a single day in her life. Also like Mrs. Dalloway and the other protagonists of *The Hours*, Laura spends her day preparing for a party. In Laura's case, this includes baking a **cake** for Dan's birthday. Laura loves to escape her daily life through reading and feels that Virginia Woolf must have understood the exact same things Laura is going through—like Woolf, Woolf's character Mrs. Dalloway, and Clarissa, Laura feels stifled by her domestic life, particularly by her attraction to other women, which she feels unable to act on. Laura desires her neighbor and good friend Kitty. At one point, the women share a passionate kiss, but the intimate moment ends abruptly before either can acknowledge what happened between them. While a part of Laura resents having to spend so much of her time on her family, another part of her feels that it is her duty to be the best wife and mother possible, motivating her to throw out the first cake she makes for Dan and try to make a better one. Her commitment to her domestic obligations repress her need for solitude and individuality, and as a result, she experiences constant anxiety and frequent suicidal thoughts. At one point, in order to give herself a few uninterrupted hours of reading time, she leaves Richie with a babysitter and secretly rents a hotel room and spends the afternoon reading there. She subsequently spends the rest of the day feeling guilty and ashamed of her impulsive decision. Laura reappears in the novel's present day as an elderly woman following the suicide of her adult son, Richard.

Virginia Woolf – Virginia Woolf is the real-life author of *Mrs. Dalloway*, a novel that greatly influences the lives of Laura and Clarissa in the latter two timelines of *The Hours*. She appears in a slightly fictionalized form in this novel. As the prologue reveals, Virginia will eventually kill herself by drowning, but during the day in her life that is the main focus of *The Hours*, Virginia is living in Richmond, a suburb of London, with her husband, Leonard. She is in the middle of writing *Mrs. Dalloway* but has been making slow progress due to poor health and her fear that her bad headaches will return if she overexerts herself. Like the titular protagonist of her novel *Mrs. Dalloway*, Virginia is also preparing to host a social event later in the day, with her older sister, Vanessa, coming over with her children for tea. Although Virginia's life may seem happy on the surface, she feels stifled by domesticity, forced to obey her husband Leonard, unable to communicate with servants like Nelly, and mostly unable to act on her attraction to women. All of these factors lead Virginia to fantasize about taking a train back to London, where she hopes things will feel more vibrant and alive. But just after Virginia buys a train ticket, she runs into

Leonard and decides to go back to her Richmond home instead of taking the train. This fictional portrayal of Virginia Woolf reveals the large and small struggles she endured in her private life, many of which derived from feelings of repression and entrapment she felt to due to her society's gender double standards and its condemnation of homosexuality—and which persist into the novel's present, affecting both Laura and Clarissa.

Richard/Richie – Richard (known as “Richie” as a child) is the young son of Laura and Dan in one timeline of the story. He also features in the novel's modern-day timeline as an acclaimed poet dying of AIDS. His close friend Clarissa serves as his primary caregiver. As a boy, Richie watches everything his mother does and seems very sensitive and prone to crying. As an adult, Richard becomes a witty writer, meeting Clarissa and Louis in college and at one point attempting a three-way relationship with them. On the day the novel's present-day timeline follows, Richard is set to receive an award called the Carrouthers Prize, which he has mixed feelings about: he feels that his illness has greatly diminished him and that he may only be receiving the award out of pity. Although the longest relationship of Richard's life was with Louis, the one long novel that Richard writes focuses on a female character that many feel bears a strong resemblance to Clarissa (although Clarissa herself feels the character is just a fantasy idea of her). At first, Richard seems very different from his namesake (Richard Dalloway, Clarissa Dalloway's husband) in the Virginia Woolf novel *Mrs. Dalloway*: Richard Dalloway is a practical government worker, whereas this Richard lives the more bohemian life of a poet. But despite his seemingly freer lifestyle, the Richard of *The Hours* becomes a part of the literary establishment, raising the question of whether he is really the opposite of his namesake or if his life simply reflects how society's vision of prestige and respectability have changed over time. Ultimately, Richard's life ends in suicide when he jumps to his death from the window of his fifth-story apartment.

Sally – Sally is a public television producer who is in a long-term partnership with Clarissa, with whom she has a daughter, Julia. Sally was also the name of the woman in *Mrs. Dalloway* whom Clarissa Dalloway loved but couldn't be with, so in many ways, this timeline of the novel stands as a modern-day, hypothetical scenario that imagines how life might have been if Clarissa Dalloway had ended up with Sally rather than staying with her husband, Richard. Sally and Clarissa do indeed have perhaps the most supportive relationship of the three main relationships in the novel, but even they have secrets, with Clarissa longing for the past she shared with her old friend Richard, and with Sally making Clarissa feel excluded when Sally gets involved in the world of show business (even though Sally herself sometimes feels out of her element around industry people like Oliver St. Ives).

Louis – Louis is a big man who can seem like a simple farm boy on the surface but who hides greater complexity, and he spends much of his life in a relationship with Richard. Clarissa, Louis, and Richard all knew one another in college and seemed to even attempt a polyamorous relationship, but Clarissa's incompatibility with Louis ultimately led to Richard and Louis forming their own partnership. Louis was not always happy with Richard, particularly when it seemed like Richard was still obsessing over Clarissa, but in the end, it was Richard who decided to end the relationship. After Richard, Louis frequently has relationships with his much-younger students, suggesting that like Richard and Clarissa, he is anxious about aging and clings in vain to his youth.

Leonard – Leonard is the husband of Virginia Woolf. He is also a writer and a publisher, and he is very particular about when and how he works. Although he seems to care for Virginia, he can be very controlling, often in subtle ways, like when he forces her to stay in the suburb of Richmond instead of living in London, all supposedly for her health. The novel draws a connection between Leonard and the character Richard (Mrs. Dalloway's husband) in Virginia's novel, *Mrs. Dalloway*—though not cruel, Richard nevertheless limits his wife Clarissa in many ways.

Julia – Julia is the daughter of Clarissa and Sally. She spends a lot of time with an older queer theorist named Mary Krull who influences Julia's opinions and way of dressing, although the relationship seems to be platonic, particularly from Julia's perspective. Julia bears some resemblance to Elizabeth Dalloway (the daughter of Clarissa Dalloway in Virginia Woolf's *Mrs. Dalloway*). Like Elizabeth, Julia's modern behaviors and ways of thinking sometimes confuse her mother.

Dan – Dan is a former war hero who somewhat unexpectedly decides to marry the bookish Laura. Together, they have a young son named Richie. Although Dan seems supportive of Laura and even sympathetic to her mental health issues, he ultimately fails to understand her on a deeper level, forcing her to seek out understanding in other ways, like reading Virginia Woolf. As a loyal husband who nevertheless fails to see many important things about his wife, he is yet another man in the story who resembles Richard Dalloway from *Mrs. Dalloway*.

Walter – Walter is a writer in a relationship with Evan. He is a friend of both Richard and Clarissa, although when Clarissa invites him to Richard's party to celebrate a literary award Richard has recently won, Walter seems jealous of Richard's professional success. Walter's own writing is more romantic and sentimental, leading to less critical acclaim.

Kitty – Kitty is Laura's next-door neighbor and the wife of Ray. Though Laura envies Kitty for her self-assurance, she also feels sympathy for her, believing that Kitty's husband, Ray, a war veteran, doesn't treat Kitty well. Laura secretly desires Kitty and at one point even kisses her after learning that Kitty has to

go to the hospital to get an unusual growth examined. However, the intimate moment comes to an abrupt end when Laura realizes that her son, Richie, witnessed the interaction.

Evan – Evan is the partner of Walter who seemed to be dying due to complications of HIV but whose health has improved due to contracting the illness later and benefiting from new medical advances. Evan’s situation contrasts with that of Richard, who didn’t have access to the same medical advances back when he first got sick and whose illness has now progressed too far to benefit from new treatment options.

Oliver St. Ives – Oliver St. Ives is a movie star who is gay but makes a name for himself playing heterosexual characters in thrillers. He loses a role when he comes out as openly gay but also gets a major magazine feature. He enlists Sally and Walter to help him get a new movie produced.

Ray – Ray is Kitty’s husband. He never physically appears in the story and is only mentioned in passing. He served in the military and was captured as a prisoner of war, an experience that prematurely aged him. Laura initially believes that Ray is the reason Kitty has no children, but the actual reason turns out to be a growth on Kitty’s uterus.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Vanessa – Vanessa is the older sister of Virginia Woolf. To Virginia, she represents a type of domestic ideal, able to manage three children and her servants with seeming ease. When Virginia kisses Vanessa on the lips, it seems to stir Virginia’s desire for women.

Mary Krull – Mary Krull is a queer theorist in her forties who becomes a mentor and friend to Julia, Clarissa’s daughter. Clarissa and Mary each judge the other’s life choices, with Clarissa believing that Mary is militant and even hypocritical in her radical beliefs, and Mary believing that Clarissa is repressed.

Nelly – Nelly is the servant of Virginia and Leonard. Virginia wants to control Nelly while also earning her respect, but she struggles to do either.

Ralph – Ralph is an assistant to Leonard who helps him with his publishing work—one of many assistants who come and go.

Mrs. Latch – Mrs. Latch is the neighbor of Laura who watches Richie while she goes out on an “errand” (though Laura in fact spends the afternoon reading *Mrs. Dalloway* in a hotel room she rents to have a few hours of privacy).

black and white.



THE PASSAGE OF TIME

Michael Cunningham’s *The Hours* is a novel about three women whose lives intertwine, though their stories unfold at different periods in the 20th century: a fictionalized version of the writer Virginia Woolf, Laura Brown, and Clarissa Vaughan. In one sense, the novel all takes place in a single day, starting in the morning and advancing into the night, but this “day” takes place across three different timelines, with each new chapter taking place in a different time period. On the one hand, each woman struggles with the idea that time is passing too quickly and that life is slipping away from her. In the 1920s, Virginia wants to write many more novels but she fears that if she spends too much time writing on any given day, she’ll risk the return of her painful headaches. Meanwhile, in the 1940s, Laura struggles with all the tasks she has to complete, like baking a **cake**, in time for her husband’s birthday before he gets back from work—all of which leaves her with no time to herself. Finally, Clarissa, in the novel’s present (1990s) struggles with the idea that she never got to have a full romantic relationship with Richard, who due to AIDS and the passing of time, is no longer even the same person.

But while each thread of the story examines the consequences of the passage of time, the novel also explores how some things remain the same over time. Clarissa’s life in the novel’s present strongly resembles that of the titular character (also named Clarissa) in Virginia Woolf’s *Mrs. Dalloway*, a novel written almost a century before, with Clarissa herself in the titular role and her friend Richard resembling the suicidal, poetry-loving character Septimus. Similarly, Laura’s attempts to escape her stifling suburban life have strong parallels to Virginia’s own fantasies about getting out of suburban Richmond. The common elements among these parallel stories emphasize how some of life’s challenges remain the same for people—especially women—across time. *The Hours* explores the anxiety and deterioration that the passage of time can cause, but it also highlights how some essential truths about humanity remain true even across different periods of time.



SUICIDE AND MENTAL HEALTH

Each of the three main women in *The Hours* contemplates or dies by suicide at some point in the novel, with Virginia killing herself in the prologue and with Laura and Clarissa surviving their own suicidal impulses but having to cope with the suicide of Richard. And these characters’ actions echo the events of the novel *Mrs. Dalloway*, where the character Mrs. Dalloway contemplates suicide and the character Septimus ultimately dies by it). Their actions also echo the real life of *Mrs. Dalloway*’s author, Virginia



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in

Woolf, who, just like her lightly fictionalized counterpart in this novel, drowned herself in a river. The novel delves into the mental health of its three protagonists, showing how each woman takes on a heavy mental burden to deal with the pressures of daily life while also showing how a perceived sense of failure can prevent them from enjoying their successes. Virginia's mental health problems manifest physically as headaches that limit her ability to write and keep her trapped outside of London in the suburb of Richmond. Laura's anxiety makes it feel like nothing she ever does for her husband, Dan, will ever be good enough. Finally, Clarissa's own anxiety about her relationship with her friend and former lover Richard causes her to stress over every detail of his upcoming party, right down the type of **flowers** in her house.

It is fittingly tragic, then, that the death of Richard is the event that brings all three protagonists of the story together. The ending reveals how, as much as suicide plays a key role in lives of each of the protagonists, perhaps what really defines the three of them is their status as survivors. Even Virginia, the only protagonist who does indeed kill herself, lives for many years after the day of her life depicted in the novel, and her works continue to be relevant long after her death. Laura lives even longer, making it into her 80s and surviving the deaths of Dan and both her children. Finally, in the aftermath of Richard's death, Clarissa experiences grief, but she also uses the moment as a chance to finally separate from her old persona as "Mrs. Dalloway" (a nickname Richard gave her) and try to start a new phase of her life. *The Hours* examines how mental health struggles can make life unbearable while also celebrating the resilience that people can find to survive despite mental health challenges.



MARRIAGE, RELATIONSHIPS, AND PERSONAL FULFILLMENT

The three main women in *The Hours* are each in a marriage or long-term partnership that compromises their ability to be fully and freely themselves. Virginia feels trapped by her husband, Leonard, and his commanding attitude. She wishes she could leave behind the quiet suburb of Richmond to return to the excitement of London. Decades later, Laura identifies with Virginia's novel *Mrs. Dalloway* because she is trapped in her own marriage with Dan, which seems ideal on the surface—but which leaves her with no time to herself. Finally, Clarissa struggles with the fear that her stable, long-lasting partnership with Sally has turned her into a boring housewife and prevented her from being in a relationship with Richard, whose own life as a writer seems much more glamorous. In each timeline, the protagonist longs for freedom from responsibility but can't escape her daily routine, which often requires her to take on more responsibility than the other person in the relationship.

The novel suggests that the conventions of heterosexual

marriage can create and perpetuate gender inequality, with Virginia and Laura each seemingly devoting more time and effort to their family and domestic chores than their male partners, but even Clarissa struggles to communicate with her partner, Sally. Meanwhile, the novel shows how the institution of marriage enforces heterosexual gender roles, forcing people to repress potential homosexual feelings. Virginia's longing for a relationship with a woman comes out when she kisses her own sister Vanessa, and this leads to repressed female desire becoming a key part of Mrs. Dalloway, a character in the book she is currently writing. Meanwhile, Laura begins to desire her neighbor Kitty but can't act on her attraction because of her marriage to Dan and her need to care for Richie. Finally, while Clarissa has the most relationship freedom, at one point attempting a three-way relationship with Richard and Louis, she finds that arrangement unsatisfying. She instead seeks out a more dependable, monogamous relationship with Sally, causing people like Richard and the queer theorist Mary Krull to look down on Clarissa for replicating the conventions of a heterosexual marriage—and all the problems of gender inequality and repressed desires that come with them. *The Hours* thus portrays how any committed relationship, not just heterosexual marriage, can restrict a person's personal freedom and self-expression, leading to repressed desires and to feelings of resentment and unfulfillment.



READING AND WRITING

The women of Michael Cunningham's *The Hours* are all united by the novel *Mrs. Dalloway*, which Virginia writes, and which Laura and Clarissa later read. For Virginia, writing is both a release and a weight on her. It provides structure to her life, occupying her thoughts even when she can't actually be writing, but it also haunts her with the feeling that she needs to be doing more. Laura struggles with similar feelings of inadequacy, but her anxieties pertain to reading instead of writing. She relishes the time when she can disappear into a novel like *Mrs. Dalloway*, but reading the novel in the "right" conditions becomes an obsession for her, to the point where she rents a hotel room for the night, just to read for two solitary, uninterrupted hours. Finally, as a publisher, Clarissa occupies a role somewhere between reading and writing. While a mutual love of *Mrs. Dalloway* is a key element of Clarissa's relationship with Richard, a part of Clarissa resents the ways that Richard tries to flatten her into a character, both by calling her "Mrs. Dalloway" and by loosely basing the suicidal main character of his own novel on her.

While literature—particularly *Mrs. Dalloway*—connects three women from different circumstances and eras, it also ends up meaning something different to each of them. For all three women, fiction represents a necessary form of escapism, but it also has important limits. No amount of reading can fix Laura's feelings about her marriage, for instance. Meanwhile, Virginia's

successful completion of *Mrs. Dalloway* doesn't Virginia's mental health issues. And helping authors publish "difficult" (meaning literary and unprofitable) novels doesn't improve Clarissa's self-esteem. Whereas literature is a way for Virginia to communicate with a future she won't live to see, for Laura and Clarissa it is a way for them to connect to the past and realize that the challenges they face in their own lives aren't new. *The Hours* celebrates the power of reading and writing to connect people across time and to help them escape their ordinary lives, but it also demonstrates the limits of literature, showing how in the end it can't fully reflect life's complexities or provide a solution to them.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



FLOWERS

Flowers are an important symbol in Virginia Woolf's novel *Mrs. Dalloway*, and in *The Hours*, which is modeled after Woolf's novel, flowers symbolize the beauty of life, but also its shortness and fragility. Like Woolf's *Mrs. Dalloway*, Clarissa spends her morning thinking about buying flowers for Richard's party that evening. As Richard himself notes at one point, flowers can serve two main purposes, being either a gesture of congratulations (like Clarissa intends them to be at Richard's party) or condolences (like at a funeral). Clarissa initially buys flowers for a party where she hopes to impress Richard. The flowers perhaps have a romantic undertone, illustrating Clarissa's nostalgia for her youth and her missed opportunity to have a long-term relationship with Richard. In this instance, flowers represent Clarissa's mixed emotions about her past with Richard: though it's a period of her life she looks back on fondly, the feelings of loss and missed chances at love she associates with it fills her with sadness and regret, too. Meanwhile, when Clarissa later finds out that she and her current partner, Sally, both bought flowers, it reminds her that, while she and Sally sometimes take each other for granted, they still have things in common, and this renews Clarissa's sense of gratitude and appreciation for her life.

But although flowers are beautiful, they also foreshadow the darker events that occur near the end of the novel. While Virginia, in the book's 1920s timeline, is writing *Mrs. Dalloway*, she witnesses Vanessa's children laying flowers around a dead bird in her backyard, suggesting the flowers' relationship to death and the suffering that characterizes life. At the end of *The Hours*, the flowers that Clarissa (whose nickname is "Mrs. Dalloway") bought become a memorial to Richard after she watches him die by suicide, and the gathering of friends she has

organized becomes mournful rather than celebratory. The symbolism of Clarissa's flowers thus reaffirms the fragile, fleeting, and unpredictable nature of life.



CAKE

Laura Brown spends much of her day baking a cake for her husband, Dan, and this cake symbolizes Laura's conflicting feelings about the many burdens that society obligates women to take on as wives and mothers. Laura wakes up late on the morning of her husband's birthday, partly because she was up late the previous night reading Virginia Woolf's novel *Mrs. Dalloway*, but also because she generally finds household work exhausting. Although Laura fears and perhaps even resents all the responsibilities she has, she nevertheless wants to succeed at them. She and her son, Richie, make a cake together in what seems to be a moment of triumph, as Laura bonds with Richie and teaches him about baking. But Laura is ultimately unhappy with the finished cake, feeling it's too sloppy, so she throws it out and starts a new one. Laura's dissatisfaction with the cake represents her complicated relationship to her domestic responsibilities. Though she resents and feels somewhat stifled by them, she simultaneously wants to succeed at them and feels like a failure when her efforts don't pay off.

Laura eventually makes a second cake that comes closer to her ideal. But the stress that the whole ordeal propels Laura to drop Richie off with a babysitter and rent hotel room for herself in order to have a couple hours of uninterrupted time to read *Mrs. Dalloway* by herself. Laura's need for solitude shows the degree to which baking the cake—and the pressure of performing her duties as a wife and mother in general—exhausts Laura. Later that evening, Dan says that Laura has given him a perfect birthday, suggesting that Laura's efforts—however fraught—have paid off. However, when he accidentally spits on her cake as he blows out the candles, it suggests that he doesn't understand or appreciate all the work she does for him. Cake, in this way, symbolizes how much of the work that women do as wives and mothers goes unseen and unappreciated.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Picador edition of *The Hours* published in 1998.

Prologue Quotes

☛ She hurries from the house, wearing a coat too heavy for the weather. It is 1941. Another war has begun. She has left a note for Leonard, and another for Vanessa.

Related Characters: Virginia Woolf, Leonard, Vanessa

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 3

Explanation and Analysis

This quote appears at the beginning of the novel's prologue, which presents a lightly fictionalized version of the day of Virginia Woolf's death by suicide. Right from beginning, it's clear that something is wrong, with Virginia's too-heavy jacket foreshadowing how she will fill her pockets with rocks in order to drown.

The year 1941 is also significant, since it falls near the beginning of World War II, a tumultuous time in world history. Woolf's novels, particularly *Mrs. Dalloway* deal with the trauma of World War I, and while Cunningham does not attempt to explain Woolf's suicide, he does reference the war in a way that invites comparisons between the turmoil in Europe and Woolf's own mental state at the time. The opening of the novel foreshadows the role that suicide (and mortality in general) will play throughout all the different timelines of the novel, but it also serves the purpose of getting Virginia's suicide out of the way early, so that the remainder of the novel can focus on her life rather than fixating on her death.

Chapter 1: Mrs. Dalloway Quotes

☝ There are still the flowers to buy. Clarissa feigns exasperation (though she loves doing errands like this), leaves Sally cleaning the bathroom, and runs out, promising to be back in half an hour.

It is New York City. It is the end of the twentieth century.

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan, Virginia Woolf, Sally

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 9

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is the beginning of the first numbered chapter in the novel, introducing one of the three main characters—Clarissa—and her partner, Sally. The quote immediately connects the novel to *Mrs. Dalloway*, which also begins with a character named Clarissa thinking about flowers. Like *Mrs. Dalloway*, *The Hours* aims to portray the

hidden complexities everyday life, and so it's fitting that the novel begins with the mundane activities of doing errands and cleaning the bathroom.

The Hours was published in 1998, and so its "end of the twentieth century" setting was more or less present-day at the time. By inventing a character like Clarissa, who is so similar to Woolf's character Mrs. Dalloway, Cunningham aims to show how Woolf and her ideas continue to be relevant even in a very different era. At the same time, however, Clarissa and her story provide an opportunity to show what *has* changed with the passage of time and how *Mrs. Dalloway* would have to be different to work in the present.

Chapter 2: Mrs. Woolf Quotes

☝ Writing in that state is the most profound satisfaction she knows, but her access to it comes and goes without warning. She may pick up her pen and follow it with her hand as it moves across the paper; she may pick up her pen and find that she's merely herself, a woman in a housecoat holding a pen, afraid and uncertain, only mildly competent, with no idea about where to begin or what to write.

Related Characters: Virginia Woolf, Leonard

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 35

Explanation and Analysis

This quote jumps back in time to Richmond in the 1920s, when Virginia was drafting the novel that would become *Mrs. Dalloway*. The passage describes Virginia's writing process. Although Woolf becomes a famous writer, both in the real world and in a fictionalized version in the later timelines of this novel, this quote captures her in a state of uncertainty, when she wasn't sure if she'd ever even finish *Mrs. Dalloway*.

Virginia feels a lack of control related to her writing, as if the pen is the thing that decides whether she has a productive day of writing or whether her work is barely even competent. In particular, she worries if she's just "a woman in a housecoat with a pen." This reveals how Virginia's insecurities connect to her status as a woman. In 1920s British society, women lacked control and were expected to prioritize the needs of their husbands, as Virginia herself sometimes does for Leonard. And so, Virginia's fears about writing in this quote hint at how patriarchal societies discourage self-expression in women.

Chapter 3: Mrs. Brown Quotes

☞ She inhales deeply. It is so beautiful; it is so much more than...well, than almost anything, really. In another world, she might have spent her whole life reading. But this is the new world, the rescued world—there's not much room for idleness. So much has been risked and lost; so many have died.

Related Characters: Laura Brown, Virginia Woolf, Dan

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 39

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes Laura Brown's reaction to reading Woolf's *Mrs. Dalloway*, which is so rapturous that it causes her to stay up late at night reading and then stay in bed the next morning to read more. Laura sees *Mrs. Dalloway* as being more alive and beautiful than her own life, even though the novel famously focuses on everyday matters. And so, this passage captures the power of writing, which can transform stories about ordinary events into something so thrilling that they become an escape from the everyday.

Laura's thoughts about a "new world" where "much has been risked and lost" are a reference to World War II. Virginia herself didn't live to see the end of World War II, but because so much of her work deals with the consequences of World War I, it makes sense that Laura would continue to find resonance in Virginia's work. Laura's guilt about reading relates to the fact that, as a soldier in World War II, her husband, Dan, played a role in making the "new world." Similar to Virginia in the previous chapter, Laura's situation shows how patriarchy discourages women from pursuing their own interests, sometimes forcing them to do so in secret.

Chapter 4: Mrs. Dalloway Quotes

☞ Richard's chair, particularly, is insane; or, rather, it is the chair of someone who, if not actually insane, has let things slide so far, has gone such a long way toward the exhausted relinquishment of ordinary caretaking—simple hygiene, regular nourishment—that the difference between insanity and hopelessness is difficult to pinpoint. The chair—an elderly, square, overstuffed armchair obesely balanced on slender blond wooden legs—is ostentatiously broken and worthless.[...] Richard will not hear of its being replaced.

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan, Richard/Richie, Louis

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 58

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the chair in Richard's apartment, which has symbolic significance that helps reveal Richard's own personality. On the outside, Richard might seem like an imposing figure, someone who has had a lot of literary success and who is about to receive a major award. But Clarissa has known Richard longer than almost anyone, and she can see how AIDS has left him in a state of decline, much like his tired old chair.

The age and run-down condition of the chair show the effect that time has had on Richard as well. Moreover, the chair is "overstuffed," perhaps reflecting how Richard's one published novel is over 900 pages and yet still seems to fail in its goal of portraying a character that captures the essence of Clarissa. Richard's refusal to replace his old chair seems to reflect his own fear of becoming irrelevant. Like many characters in the story, he wants to hold on to part of his past as a way of coping with an uncertain future.

Chapter 5: Mrs. Woolf Quotes

☞ She decides, with misgivings, that she is finished for today. Always, there are these doubts. Should she try another hour? Is she being judicious, or slothful? Judicious, she tells herself, and almost believes it. She has her two hundred and fifty words, more or less. Let it be enough. Have faith that you will be here, recognizable to yourself, again tomorrow.

Related Characters: Laura Brown, Virginia Woolf, Leonard

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 72

Explanation and Analysis

This quote captures Virginia's thoughts as she ends her writing for the day, still fairly early in the morning. The quote, like much of Virginia's story, challenges traditional ideas of what a great writer is like. Although later characters like Laura see Virginia as a brilliant, larger-than-life figure, Virginia herself feels lazy and insecure, spending a relatively small fraction of her day on the physical act of writing.

Virginia both fears writing and needs it so survive. All of her writing comes with the fear that too much exertion will bring back her painful headaches. And yet, writing provides a necessary outlet for Virginia, providing her with hope and

helping her look forward to each new day, which brings another opportunity to write. Once again, Virginia's guilt about taking time for herself hints at how patriarchal societies discourage women from spending time on self-expression.

Chapter 6: Mrs. Brown Quotes

☛ It seems suddenly easy to bake a cake, to raise a child. She loves her son purely, as mothers do—she does not resent him, does not wish to leave.

Related Characters: Laura Brown, Richard/Richie, Dan

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 79

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes Laura making a birthday cake for her husband, Dan, after Dan leaves for work that day. At first, Laura felt anxiety about being left alone with her son, Richie, and about having to finish a cake for Dan before he returns home, but after Laura gets started on the task, she finds that it goes better than she expected.

Making the cake gives Laura an opportunity to bond with Richie, who can be an emotional child. As this quote reveals, Laura's feelings toward Richie are complicated—while she does love him, particularly in this moment, she also seems to finally admit to herself that sometimes she resents Richie. Richie represents Laura's constant burden to be a mother, and as later chapters explore in more detail, Richie is always observing Laura, giving her almost nowhere in her house to go when she wants privacy. This quote explores Laura's complicated feelings toward motherhood and how one woman can simultaneously want to be a good mother while also wanting to leave the whole role of motherhood behind.

Chapter 7: Mrs. Woolf Quotes

☛ She will give Clarissa Dalloway great skill with servants, a manner that is intricately kind and commanding. Her servants will love her. They will do more than she asks.

Related Characters: Virginia Woolf, Leonard, Nelly

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 87

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Virginia thinks about her novel-in-progress, *Mrs. Dalloway*, after a disagreement with her servant Nelly. Nelly makes a casual comment about how she will be serving pears with lunch unless Virginia would like something fancier. This comment has a big effect on Virginia, who really doesn't want pears but who also doesn't like the idea that Nelly thinks she needs fancy things.

This quote explores the complicated power dynamic in the Woolf household. Although Virginia is Nelly's employer, Virginia struggles with how to exercise authority over her, perhaps because Virginia is used to playing a more passive role when she's with her husband, Leonard. Unable to be the type of person she wants to be in real life, Virginia incorporates her desires into her fiction, making the fictional Mrs. Dalloway an ideal woman who somehow manages to exercise control over her servants while still holding on to their love. Notably, in the finished novel, Mrs. Dalloway is not a perfectly content character but instead one who is constantly haunted by thoughts of the past, suggesting that even if Virginia became her ideal self, she would still deal with regrets.

Chapter 8: Mrs. Dalloway Quotes

☛ How often since then has she wondered what might have happened if she'd tried to remain with him; if she'd returned Richard's kiss on the corner of Bleecker and MacDougal, gone off somewhere (where?) with him, never bought the packet of incense or the alpaca coat with the rose-shaped buttons. Couldn't they have discovered something...larger and stranger than what they've got?

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan, Richard/Richie, Sally

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 97

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, as Clarissa walks around New York City, she thinks back to the past, remembering the brief moment in college when it seemed like she could have found happiness in a romantic relationship with Richard rather than the platonic one she currently has with him. Clarissa imagines that the whole course of her life hinged on a single moment, and if she had just kissed Richard back on a certain corner,

her life would've gone in a different direction.

The rest of the chapter and the novel challenge this notion, however. While the novel captures how everyday actions can be surprisingly significant, it becomes clear that Richard and Clarissa's relationship is probably too complicated to fix with one kiss several decades ago. As Clarissa herself eventually realizes, perhaps what she's longing for, even more than a relationship with Richard, is a way to return to that feeling of excitement and potential that she felt when she was younger. Like many characters in the novel, Clarissa tries to fight against the flow of time, refusing to accept that her advancing age has continued to limit her possibilities for the future.

Chapter 9: Mrs. Brown Quotes

☛☛ Laura releases Kitty. She steps back. She has gone too far, they've both gone too far, but it is Kitty who's pulled away first. It is Kitty whose terrors have briefly propelled her, caused her to act strangely and desperately. Laura is the dark-eyed predator. Laura is the odd one, the foreigner, the one who can't be trusted. Laura and Kitty agree, silently, that this is true.

Laura glances over at Richie. He is still holding the red truck. He is still watching.

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan, Laura Brown, Richard/Richie, Kitty

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 110

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes during a surprising moment in the novel when, after Kitty reveals that she has to go to the hospital to have a growth checked out, she and Laura tentatively kiss on the lips. Lips are an important image in the story, with Clarissa's inability to kiss people on the lips being a sign of her own fear of intimacy, and so when Kitty and Laura touch lips, it hints at sexual desires that both of them have repressed.

In addition to hinting at the unfortunate social stigmas attached to homosexuality at the time, Laura's guilt after kissing Kitty show yet again how Laura feels shame about anything that distracts her from her role as a wife and mother. Whether it's true or not, Laura feels that Richie is constantly watching and judging her, leaving her with no room to make mistakes. This moment helps Laura realize

how trapped she is in her current domestic situation, motivating her to look for a way out.

Chapter 10: Mrs. Woolf Quotes

☛☛ Before following them, Virginia lingers another moment beside the dead bird in its circle of roses. It could be a kind of hat. It could be the missing link between millinery and death. She would like to lie down in its place. No denying it, she would like that.

Related Characters: Virginia Woolf, Richard/Richie, Vanessa

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 121

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Vanessa arrives early at Virginia's house with her children, and the kids discover a bird that's on the brink of death. The children hold a funeral for the bird, and afterwards, Virginia stays behind to examine it alone. The flowers from the funeral, which symbolize beauty and life, contrast with the dead bird itself. Virginia's claim that the bird could be a type of hat suggests that she sees beauty in the strange contrast between the living roses and dead bird.

And so, Virginia's longing to be the dead bird is not just about suicide but also about the desire to be surrounded by beautiful things, like the flowers around the bird. Both death and beauty seem to offer potential ways for Virginia to escape her typical domestic life. In addition to its significance in Virginia's life, the dead bird foreshadows the ending of the novel, where Richard momentarily becomes birdlike as he jumps out of his apartment window to his death.

Chapter 11: Mrs. Dalloway Quotes

☛☛ The truth is that he does not love Hunter and Hunter does not love him. They are having an affair; only an affair. He fails to think of him for hours at a time. Hunter has other boyfriends, a whole future planned, and when he's moved on, Louis has to admit, privately, that he won't much miss Hunter's shrill laugh, his chipped front tooth, his petulant silences.

There is so little love in the world.

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan, Laura Brown, Virginia Woolf, Richard/Richie, Louis

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 134

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is one of the rare parts of the novel that follows the thoughts of a character other than one of the three protagonists (Clarissa, Laura, and Virginia). In this moment, the narrative tracks Richard's former partner Louis. Although Louis told Clarissa that he is in love with one of his much-younger students (Hunter Croydon), in fact, Louis knows well that his relationship with Hunter is much more casual than love.

As Clarissa notes to herself later, Louis has a bit of a reputation for having relationships with students. This suggests how, just as Clarissa keeps obsessing over her past in college and Richard refuses to throw out his old chair, Louis uses his relationships with younger men as his own way to hold on to the past and attempt to feel the way he did in college. When Louis thinks about it, he doesn't even like many of Hunter's traits, but Hunter has "a whole future planned" and this may be what attracts Louis, just as a similar desire has attracted so many other characters in the novel.

Chapter 12: Mrs. Brown Quotes

☛ Leaving the desk, she can hardly believe she's done it. She has gotten the key, passed through the portals.

Related Characters: Laura Brown, Virginia Woolf, Richard/Richie, Dan

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 148

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Laura can't believe that, in order to find a private place to read *Mrs. Dalloway* in peace for a couple hours, she actually checked out a room at a reasonably nice hotel for a whole night. The idea that it's possible to do such a thing shocks her, not because she's doing anything particularly immoral, but because she didn't feel that she could ever escape the watchful eye of Richie or the duties she has for Dan.

Laura feels that the hotel is like a portal to somewhere new, where her domestic duties are a distant concern. This state

of mind allows her to read *Mrs. Dalloway* with a clarity and vividness that she has never experienced before. Laura begins to imagine that she actually is Virginia Woolf, writing the novel instead of reading it. But Laura's new freedom also comes with consequences, as she finds that even in the privacy of her hotel room she can't escape suicidal thoughts, suggesting the internal emotional struggles she deals with.

Chapter 13: Mrs. Woolf Quotes

☛ Nelly turns away and, although it is not at all their custom, Virginia leans forward and kisses Vanessa on the mouth. It is an innocent kiss, innocent enough, but just now, in this kitchen, behind Nelly's back, it feels like the most delicious and forbidden of pleasures. Vanessa returns the kiss.

Related Characters: Laura Brown, Virginia Woolf, Leonard, Vanessa, Kitty, Nelly

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 154

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Virginia kisses her sister Vanessa on the lips behind the back of Virginia's servant, Nelly. The whole scene parallels an earlier moment when Kitty and Laura kissed on the lips. As the quote shows, Virginia's real interest may be less in the kiss itself and more in the "forbidden pleasure" it represents, which is particularly "delicious" because it all happens right behind Nelly's back.

It is possible to read Virginia's feelings as incestuous, but this quote seems to suggest that even an "innocent" kiss between sisters would be too intimate to do in front of Nelly. As the women of their houses, both Virginia and Vanessa have to keep up respectable and dignified appearances, even in front of servants. In this quote, Virginia tests out what happens when she deviates from her conventional domestic role. Vanessa's willingness to kiss Virginia back seems to encourage Virginia to continue pushing boundaries, setting the stage for the later chapters of her story.

Chapter 14: Mrs. Dalloway Quotes

☛☛ *Fool*, Mary thinks, though she struggles to remain charitable or, at least, serene. No, screw charity. Anything's better than queers of the old school, dressed to pass, bourgeois to the bone, living like husband and wife. Better to be a frank and open asshole, better to be John fucking Wayne, than a well-dressed dyke with a respectable job.

Fraud, Clarissa thinks. You've fooled my daughter, but you don't fool me. I know a conquistador when I see one. I know all about making a splash. It isn't hard. If you shout loud enough, for long enough, a crowd will gather to see what all the noise is about. It's the nature of crowds. They don't stay long, unless you give them reason. You're just as bad as most men, just that aggressive, just that self-aggrandizing, and your hour will come and go.

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan, Julia, Mary Krull

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 160

Explanation and Analysis

This quote captures an unspoken argument that Mary Krull and Clarissa seem to have when Mary comes up with Julia to visit Clarissa in her apartment. Mary's thoughts reveal that, much like Richard, Mary thinks Clarissa is behind the times, trying to justify her partnership with Sally to the world by making it "respectable" and patterning it after a heterosexual relationship.

Interestingly, Clarissa dislikes Mary for many of the same reasons that Mary dislikes Clarissa. Each accuses the other of being controlling, egotistical, and masculine. The juxtaposition of the two sides of this argument emphasizes how the two women actually have a lot in common, even if they fail to see it. In fact, each woman is mistaken about the other, with Mary overestimating how well Clarissa can "pass" as a typical housewife and with Clarissa overestimating how much of a "conquistador" Mary has been toward Julia (when, in fact, it's Mary who is obsessed with Julia, not the other way around). Mary and Clarissa each represent different sides of a debate on progress and how society and the nature of relationships should change over time.

Chapter 15: Mrs. Woolf Quotes

☛☛ She is better, she is safer, if she rests in Richmond; if she does not speak too much, write too much, feel too much; if she does not travel impetuously to London and walk through its streets; and yet she is dying this way, she is gently dying on a bed of roses.

Related Characters: Virginia Woolf, Leonard, Vanessa

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 154

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Virginia takes stock of her feelings about living in the suburb of Richmond instead of London. The passage deliberately leaves the perspective ambiguous so that it isn't clear if Virginia is thinking these thoughts herself or simply remembering things that Leonard has told her before to justify their staying in Richmond. Leonard does not necessarily seem to be a cruel man, and yet he has a way of influencing and controlling Virginia's thoughts even when he's not around to observe her.

Virginia wants to be obedient, but she feels that if she isn't able to express herself, she will slowly die (with the bed of roses recalling the dead bird's funeral from an earlier chapter). Trying not to feel "too much" is an impossible task, particularly for her, and Virginia seems to long for death because the expectations people place on her while she's alive are so difficult or even impossible to live up to.

Chapter 16: Mrs. Dalloway Quotes

☛☛ Sally hands the flowers to her and for a moment they are both simply and entirely happy. They are present, right now, and they have managed, somehow, over the course of eighteen years, to continue loving each other. It is enough. At this moment, it is enough.

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan, Sally

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 185

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes a moment when, after taking each other for granted for much of the novel, Sally and Clarissa finally have a surprising moment of connection over the fact that they both independently bought roses. For much of this chapter, Sally has been worrying about how she feels that she doesn't know how to relate to Clarissa anymore, with Clarissa not liking any of Sally's gifts and with "I love you" becoming an empty formality between them.

But after all of Sally's fretting about a gift to please Clarissa, it turns out that Sally gets the best reaction by giving Clarissa a gift she doesn't need at all: more roses. The unexpected humor of this moment draws Sally and Clarissa closer together, showing how long-term relationships become more about ordinary moments than grand gestures. In a novel in which the passing of time is often a tragic or frightening prospect, Sally and Clarissa's moment of understanding shows how one of the silver linings of time's passing is how it allows people to get to know each other on a deeper level.

Chapter 17: Mrs. Brown Quotes

☞ He will watch her forever. He will always know when something is wrong. He will always know precisely when and how much she has failed.

Related Characters: Laura Brown, Richard/Richie, Mrs. Latch

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 193

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is what Laura thinks to herself when she gets back from her rented hotel room and goes to pick up Richie from her neighbor, Mrs. Latch. Richie starts to cry as soon he sees Laura, making Laura feel guilty that perhaps Richie can sense whenever something is wrong with her.

On the one hand, Laura is being hyperbolic, suggesting that Richie has an omniscient ability to see and understand what Laura does, making him sound less like a child and more like God. But on the other hand, Laura's fears, however exaggerated, still ring true, considering that she has so little privacy as a mother that even the simple act of reading in peace requires renting a whole hotel room. Laura's story illustrates the challenge of being a mother in this postwar era, showing how the constant pressure to be there for children left little room for mothers to deal with their own mental health.

Chapter 18: Mrs. Dalloway Quotes

☞ "But there are still the hours, aren't there? One and then another, and you get through that one and then, my god, there's another. I'm so sick."

Related Characters: Richard/Richie (speaker), Clarissa Vaughan, Laura Brown, Virginia Woolf

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 197

Explanation and Analysis

Richard says this quote during part of a conversation he has with Clarissa after she walks into his apartment and finds him with one leg hanging out his fifth-story window. Clarissa fears, correctly, that Richard is contemplating suicide, partly because he is distressed over how AIDS has diminished him and partly because he has mixed his medications and seems to be a little delirious.

Richard's quote, which includes the title of the novel, succinctly captures the struggles that nearly all of the characters in the novel face. Most of the characters face struggles they can surmount, with Laura, for example, finding the energy to bake a cake for her husband, but the problem is that even after a success, it's impossible to stop the next hour from coming. As Richard's name hints, and as the final chapter confirms, he is the grown-up version of Richie, and he seems to have inherited some of Laura's mental health struggles with suicidal thoughts. This quote captures Richard at a moment between life and death, with the window symbolizing a threshold. Richard wants to die because he's reached a point where the passage of time feels like it will only bring new things to dread and endure—a dynamic that shows the danger of losing one's sense of hopeful anticipation.

☞ Richard smiles. He shakes his head. He says, "I don't think two people could have been happier than we've been." He inches forward, slides gently off the sill, and falls.

Related Characters: Richard/Richie (speaker), Clarissa Vaughan, Virginia Woolf, Leonard

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 200

Explanation and Analysis

In this moment, Richard quotes Virginia Woolf's own suicide note to Clarissa before intentionally falling out the window to his death. His words provide a fittingly literary end to a relationship that all began with deciding that Clarissa's nickname should be "Mrs. Dalloway."

Although Richard's death makes sense as part of the plot (since it parallels the suicide of Septimus in *Mrs. Dalloway*), in other ways, his final actions remain mysterious, with Clarissa unable to tell how much the old Richard was still in control versus how much he may have suffered delirium from either his illness or his medications (or both). Nevertheless, Richard's final words seem to offer one last glimpse of the witty, intelligent man he used to be, since there are many ways to interpret "I don't think two people could've been happier" in the context of Richard and Clarissa's relationship. One possible interpretation is that Richard is being ironic—while Virginia wrote those words to her husband Leonard, whom she had a long marriage with, Richard and Clarissa never had much chance to be happy together in that way. But it's also possible that Richard meant just the opposite: that perhaps Clarissa and Richard lived out their happiest lives because they were never meant to be together in the first place.

Chapter 19: Mrs. Brown Quotes

💡 The candles are lit. The song is sung. Dan, blowing the candles out, sprays a few tiny droplets of clear spittle onto the icing's smooth surface. Laura applauds and, after a moment, Richie does, too.

Related Characters: Laura Brown, Richard/Richie, Dan, Kitty, Ray

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 205

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the culmination of Laura's day. After trashing her first cake to make a new, better one, she watches Dan accidentally spit onto all her hard work. Although Laura is clearly disappointed, she feels she has to clap, and this signals to Richie that he should clap, too.

One of the reasons why this passage is significant is because earlier, Laura tried to overcome her insecurities around Kitty by rationalizing that at least Dan doesn't spit

everywhere like Ray when he talks. When Dan spits on Laura's cake, even though it's an accident, Laura realizes that maybe Dan and Ray aren't so different from each other after all. Dan is happy with the cake and his party, and yet his careless spitting reveals that he doesn't fully understand or appreciate the hard work that Laura did to prepare for the party. Laura learns that even women who can meet the high expectations to become a good wife and mother must deal with the possibility that their husband and children won't recognize or understand the work. And so, while Laura's day seems to end in a victory for her, it is yet another example of how suburban culture and the challenges of marriage can restrict a woman's freedom.

Chapter 20: Mrs. Woolf Quotes

💡 Yes, Clarissa will have loved a woman. Clarissa will have kissed a woman, only once. Clarissa will be bereaved, deeply lonely, but she will not die. She will be too much in love with life, with London.

Related Characters: Virginia Woolf, Vanessa

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 211

Explanation and Analysis

This quote, which comes near the end of Virginia's story in the novel, describes Virginia's final plans about what to do with her character Mrs. Dalloway. Previously, Virginia turned Mrs. Dalloway into a fantasy version of herself by suggesting that perhaps Mrs. Dalloway would be good at making her servants act obediently while still loving her. Here, Virginia complicates Mrs. Dalloway, giving her a tragic and unrequited love for a woman, but also making Mrs. Dalloway a survivor who continues to love her life in London.

As much as Virginia thinks about suicide in this novel, her final conception of Clarissa Dalloway suggests that perhaps Virginia's strongest desire is to live after all. Mrs. Dalloway can endure bereavement, unrequited love, and seemingly anything else that life can throw at her. While Virginia envies the dead bird she saw earlier, her new fantasy seems to be to become a woman so in love with life that nothing could make her want to die. This scene has a tragic side, given how the Prologue has already established that Virginia will die by suicide, but in a way, Virginia did succeed in her goal from this quote: she put a part of herself into the character of Mrs. Dalloway, who does indeed continue to endure even after Virginia's death.

Chapter 21: Mrs. Brown Quotes

☞ “So,” Dan says after a while. “Are you coming to bed?”

“Yes,” she says.

From far away, she can hear a dog barking.

Related Characters: Laura Brown, Dan (speaker), Richard/Richie

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 215

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes at the very end of Laura Brown’s story in the 1949 timeline. Dan has already asked if Laura will come to bed, but she didn’t respond, so now he asks again. Even though Laura says this time that she’ll come to bed with Dan, the chapter cuts off before she actually goes to bed. Even though Dan asks Laura a question rather than giving a command, this chapter still makes it clear that Dan expects sex from Laura, adding yet another item to her list of supposed responsibilities.

The barking dog that ends this chapter has symbolic significance, suggesting that, whether he realizes it or not, Dan wants Laura to be obedient just like a dog. Laura’s experiences over the course of the day, including her brief stay in the hotel room, have made her more aware both of Dan’s flaws and with the flaws of suburban domestic life in general. This thread of her story ends with a moment of uncertainty, where it is unclear whether Laura will rebel from her current life or just find some way to accept it.

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 220

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Clarissa finally meets Laura, who has grown much older in the time since that day decades ago when she baked a cake for Dan and rented a hotel room for herself. Clarissa and Laura have a lot in common, having both acted in a maternal role toward Richard (literally in Laura’s case, figuratively in Clarissa’s). They also both have gained a keen understanding of the burdens and pressures of domestic life.

Clarissa thinks at first that Laura must be the mother figure from Richard’s poetry, not considering the possibility that, just as Richard misrepresented Clarissa in his novel, he may have also misrepresented Laura in his poetry. At times, Clarissa has dreamed of being a woman like the mother in Richard’s poetry, someone who can just walk away from the demands of her current life. And so, Clarissa finds Laura’s normalness “comforting” because it seems to reassure Clarissa that her own desires about wanting to escape domestic life aren’t strange—that it’s possible to run away from your old life and still look as normal as Laura.

☞ And here she is, herself, Clarissa, not Mrs. Dalloway anymore; there is no one now to call her that. Here she is with another hour before her.

“Come in, Mrs. Brown,” she says. “Everything’s ready.”

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan (speaker), Laura Brown, Richard/Richie, Sally, Julia

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 226

Explanation and Analysis

This quote appears at the very end of the novel. After debating whether to eat the copious unused food for Richard’s party, Clarissa leaves Sally and Julia in the kitchen as she goes out to invite Laura to have some of the food. On a plot level, the ending is simple, suggesting that after the drama of Richard’s suicide, the characters are once again beginning to pick up their ordinary lives and ordinary problems. But the ending also has a deeper thematic significance: when Clarissa invites Laura to grab food, she brings the women of the story together, suggesting that perhaps these characters will be able to find companionship,

Chapter 22: Mrs. Dalloway Quotes

☞ They settle into another silence, one that is neither intimate nor particularly uncomfortable. Here she is, then, Clarissa thinks; here is the woman from Richard’s poetry. Here is the lost mother, the thwarted suicide; here is the woman who walked away. It is both shocking and comforting that such a figure could, in fact, prove to be an ordinary-looking old woman seated on a sofa with her hands in her lap.

Related Characters: Clarissa Vaughan, Laura Brown, Richard/Richie, Sally, Julia, Dan

Related Themes:    

at least for a while, with each other.

Although the ending of *The Hours* may seem grim, with Richard dead and many of the other characters still struggling with suicidal thoughts, the ending also offers hope, with Clarissa realizing that after Richard's death, she

no longer has to play the role of "Mrs. Dalloway" anymore. Clarissa's ability to pick a new identity for herself suggests that she has yet again found a way to look forward to the future again.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PROLOGUE

It's 1941 in England, near the start of World War II, and a woman (Virginia Woolf) rushes out of her home in a coat that's too heavy for the temperature. She has left a note for Leonard (her husband) and one for Vanessa (her older sister). Virginia walks toward the river, looking for stones and putting them into the pockets of her jacket. Then she walks into the river. At one point, she considers turning back, but she knows that if she does, Leonard and Vanessa will never let her out again.

Leonard finds his letter from Virginia and fears it may be a suicide note. He rushes out to find her. Meanwhile, Virginia's body floats quickly down the current of the river. After a short journey, the body stops somewhere beneath the water, near a stone column from a bridge. Above, a young boy throws a stick through the slats on the side of the bridge, and the stick floats down. A truck of soldiers passes the bridge, and the boy waves to them, so one soldier waves back. Virginia's body stays pressed to the bottom of the river.

The prologue dramatizes the real-life death of Virginia Woolf, who wrote the novel Mrs. Dalloway. The sections about Virginia's life are fictional, as they include elements from history that no one could know (like what Virginia was thinking in the moments before her death), but these sections also incorporate real facts, like that Virginia left notes for her husband and sister before she died.



Virginia's death suggests that she was the victim of forces larger than herself (represented by the current that carries her body along). The floating of Virginia's body in the river current hints at how time inevitably moves people forward. The soldiers passing the boy on the bridge hint at World War II and the tumult in Europe, which may have even played some role in motivating Virginia's suicide.



CHAPTER 1: MRS. DALLOWAY

In New York City, in June near the end of the 20th century, Clarissa Vaughan is on an errand to buy **flowers** for a party she's hosting. She is 52 and in good health. Her friend Richard, whom she's known since college, always calls her Mrs. Dalloway, after the titular character from the Virginia Woolf novel, because he feels that Clarissa deserves a great literary name and that Mrs. Dalloway makes the most sense, since that character's first name is also Clarissa.

The first main chapter of the book has several connections to Woolf's novel Mrs. Dalloway. That novel also starts with a woman named Clarissa thinking about buying flowers in a city in June, and it also features a man named Richard (although in Woolf's novel, Richard Dalloway is the name of Clarissa Dalloway's husband, not friend). The fact that this story takes place almost a century after Mrs. Dalloway suggests that the ideas of that book endure, while also perhaps suggesting that this novel will explore how society has changed since the original publication of Mrs. Dalloway.



Richard is a well-known writer who has been declining in health lately, with a low T-cell count (suggesting his HIV has progressed to AIDS). Richard is most famous for his poetry but also has written one long novel. He used to be in a relationship with Louis, but eventually Richard left Louis. Tonight, Clarissa wants to impress Richard at her party. She walks across Manhattan, passing street vendors and a statue of George Washington.

The human immunodeficiency virus (HIV) is a disease that weakens a person's immune system, and without treatment it can progress to acquired immunodeficiency syndrome (AIDS). From the early 80s until the development of effective treatments in the mid-1990s, HIV/AIDS was a major epidemic that particularly affected communities of gay men and intravenous drug users. Despite the work of activists, people infected with the disease often carried a stigma—which is reflected in the way this passage only mentions “T-cells” without explicitly stating that Richard has AIDS.



As Clarissa crosses a plaza, she runs into Walter Hardy, who is muscular and wearing a tank top. Walter tries to kiss Clarissa on the lips, and she initially turns to give her cheek, then starts turning back, eventually meeting his lips partway. Clarissa wishes she could be more decisive about kissing a friend on the mouth and feels that this is one of the reasons why her daughter (Julia) resents her.

The act of kissing comes up several times in this novel, with characters often wishing they could kiss someone on the lips but failing to be able to do it for some reason. Kissing on the lips suggests intimacy, and the fact that so many characters choose not to do it indicates that they are afraid of such intimacy.



Clarissa asks Walter about his plans for the evening and wonders if he and his partner Evan would like to come to a party she's holding in the evening for Richard, who has recently won a literary honor called the Carrouthers Prize. Walter says he'll come. Clarissa notices Walter has a strange reaction to her mention of the party and wonders if he's jealous of Richard's award—Walter is also a writer, although his works are more romantic and sentimental than Richard's. Clarissa warns him to be on time—they have to hold the party before the ceremony since Richard doesn't do late nights.

Characters in Clarissa's New York City can be open about their sexuality, contrasting sharply with other sections of this novel that depict less open earlier periods of history. Walter and Richard's differing careers raise questions about the value of different types of literature. Walter seems to reach a wider audience, but Richard gets more critical acclaim and establishment support. Despite each of their success, the novel seems to suggest that they each of them fall short of the ideal of Virginia Woolf, whose work has brilliance and also speaks to everyday people like Laura.



Clarissa parts ways with Walter and thinks about Richard. Before Richard's decline in health, he and Clarissa used to have long debates on various topics. Richard has always disapproved of Clarissa's long-term partnership with Sally, believing their relationship makes Clarissa too much like a suburban housewife. Clarissa resents this, because Sally is an intelligent woman who works as a public television producer, and Clarissa herself works in publishing, printing some pulpy books to make money but also some very unprofitable literary books.

Clarissa and Richard each represent a different side in the debate of what a queer relationship should look like. Richard believes that there is fundamentally something wrong with the traditional idea of a monogamous, heterosexual relationship, seeming to think that a queer relationship should therefore take a different form. Clarissa, who resists Richard's idea that she is a “housewife,” nevertheless puts more faith in the ideal of a monogamous, long-term relationship.



As Clarissa crosses Houston Street, she considers picking up a gift to celebrate Evan's returning health. She passes some shops in SoHo and considers buying a dress for Julia, but Julia doesn't wear dresses and prefers masculine clothes. Clarissa then passes a bookstore and is dismayed to see only one book from her publishing house in the window.

Clarissa wishes that her daughter could be more feminine, even as Clarissa herself refuses to conform to some of society's traditional ideas about femininity. This shows yet again how, even in the relatively free and open-minded context of New York City, people have complicated feelings about gender and sexuality.



Clarissa remembers being three or four and growing up in Wisconsin. One time a branch tapped against her window and then music started to play—this memory remains important to her since it is one of her first memories and seems to represent all the possibilities of life. Clarissa still wishes she could buy a gift for Evan or a dress for Julia. She gets annoyed with Mary Krull, the queer theorist who has been influencing Julia's recent fashion sense.

Although the branch doesn't literally cause the music to play, the young Clarissa associates the two events in her mind, awakening her to the possibility of beauty in nature. Clarissa continues to hold on to these ideas about the beauty of nature even decades later, as she now goes around the city in search of flowers.



Clarissa finally makes it to the florist, Barbara. Clarissa makes small talk about how she needs **flowers** for Richard's party. Barbara originally came to New York to sing opera. As they're looking at flower options, there's a crash outside. Barbara says it's probably just the film crew that's been there all morning. When Clarissa leaves the florist, she thinks she sees a famous person's head looking out of a trailer, possibly Meryl Streep or Vanessa Redgrave. The famous woman pulls her head back, but her presence seems to linger in the air.

This passage sets up a contrast between "ordinary" people like Barbara who make compromises on their dreams (in her case, opera singing) versus the rare people like the celebrity whose head appears at the end of this chapter. In many ways, this is the divide between Clarissa and Richard (who has achieved fame and acclaim in the literary world). The next chapter will challenge this divide, however, showing how even someone who has achieved the height of literary fame might nevertheless live an "ordinary" life much of the time.



CHAPTER 2: MRS. WOOLF

In Richmond (a suburb of London) in 1923, Virginia Woolf lies in bed thinking of how to begin her novel, *Mrs. Dalloway*. She imagines Mrs. Dalloway saying something, then getting **flowers**. She considers various possibilities before deciding she finally has to get up and write. Leonard is already up. Virginia gets ready in the bathroom, then goes down to take coffee.

Like all of the chapters about Woolf, this one uses the real facts of her life as the starting point for a lightly fictionalized story. Woolf's chapters explore the writing process, showing how, as much as books might seem like permanent objects when they're finished, they begin as something uncertain and full of possibility.



At the breakfast table, Leonard is reviewing proofs of a book. Leonard tries to make Virginia eat more for breakfast than just coffee, but she refuses, promising to have a big lunch. She goes back upstairs, thinking that she just needs to stay healthy so she can convince Leonard to move back to the city of London. She likes to skip eating to stay clear-headed enough to write. At last, she grabs her pen and writes "Mrs. Dalloway said she would buy the flowers herself."

In many ways, Leonard's meticulous style of working seems to bear more resemblance to the stereotype of a great writer than Virginia's approach does. Virginia, for her part, mixes her everyday thoughts (like how to move back to London) with her literary thoughts—which this novel suggests might be one of her strengths as a writer.



CHAPTER 3: MRS. BROWN

In Los Angeles in 1949, Laura Brown reads *Mrs. Dalloway*. She knows that instead of reading in bed, she should be getting up to make breakfast for her husband, Dan, and her three-year-old son, Richie. But she decides to stay in bed, figuring that she is allowed to get away with some "lapses" because she's pregnant. She plans to make Dan a birthday **cake** later and set a big bouquet of **flowers** on a table surrounded by all his presents.

In the first chapter, Clarissa remembers Richard accusing her of being a suburban housewife, and this chapter goes back to the period in time when the stereotype of the suburban housewife first began to take shape. Like Virginia and Clarissa, Laura wants to be a caring partner, but she also wants the independence to do things on her own, like read Mrs. Dalloway by herself if she chooses.



Laura reads more of *Mrs. Dalloway* and finds it very beautiful. She thinks about how just five years ago, she heard Dan was dead, only to learn two days later that he was still alive (and someone else with the same name had died). Dan could have married anyone after he came back a hero, but he'd already decided on Laura.

Laura reads another page, wondering how anyone who wrote as vividly as Virginia could ever kill herself. Laura is reading through all of Virginia's books and likes to imagine sometimes that she has some of the same brilliance in her that Virginia had. At last, she gets ready and goes down to breakfast with Dan and Richie. Laura thinks of the **cake** she'll make later in the day and the **flowers** she'll buy. Dan has already poured cereal for himself and Richie.

Laura says Dan shouldn't have let her sleep in on his birthday, but Dan says she needed the rest. Laura insists, so Dan says he'll wake her up with him the next morning. She has always been embarrassed about being three years older than him.

Dan leaves for work. Alone with Richie, Laura often feels uncertain of what to do. She tells him to finish his breakfast, then she lights a cigarette while she finishes her coffee. She thinks about how she was up until 2 a.m. the previous night reading and wonders if it's bad for the new baby. Laura tells Richie about the **cake** they're going to make together for Dan, but Richie seems unconvinced that this will actually happen.

Laura feels that she is lucky to have Dan and that because she's so lucky, it would be ungrateful not to be the best wife possible. As her day will reveal, however, being a good wife is difficult because it can involve complex and even contradictory expectations.



Reading provides Laura with an escape from her daily life, letting her imagine new possibilities. Interestingly, although Laura sees Virginia as a brilliant and free woman, in fact, Virginia dealt with many of the same problems and responsibilities in her daily life as Laura. In this sense, Laura is correct to believe that she might share some of the brilliance of Virginia.



Moment-to-moment, Dan acts in ways that seem to show he understands Laura, suggesting that the real causes of her stress are larger social expectations that go beyond Dan (although Dan still buys into these social expectations).



This section of the novel shows how, particularly in this time period, a woman's main role in marriage was often to take care of children. Another detail that helps establish the time period is Laura's cigarette—at the time, scientists had yet to establish a concrete link between smoking and lung cancer or dangers to pregnancy. This passage helps capture how times change, showing how for all Laura's anxieties about being a mother, she never considers how smoking is perhaps the biggest risk to her future baby.



CHAPTER 4: MRS. DALLOWAY

Clarissa heads with her **flowers** to Spring Street. She passes two young girls who recently saw a famous person and are arguing whether it was Meryl Streep, Susan Sarandon, or Vanessa Redgrave. Clarissa gets swept up in the excitement and waits a few more minutes to see if the person will come out again, but at last, she leaves and goes toward Richard's apartment.

Like Laura, who tries to read Virginia Woolf to experience brilliance, Clarissa seeks out this celebrity as a way to experience something more than daily life. But, as she has to wait for a long time, she senses that perhaps the reality of greatness can't live up to the promise and anticipation.



Clarissa remembers how the part of the city she's in used to be wilder, with bars, coffeehouses, and the sound of music. She passes a corner where Richard may have kissed her, but she doesn't remember specifically. She feels undesirable next to Louis, who is big but not dumb, like someone the Renaissance artist Michelangelo might draw. Clarissa remembers arguing with Richard on that corner and believes that even though the argument didn't seem significant at the time, it was a major turning point in their relationship.

As Clarissa walks down Bleecker Street and turns onto Thompson Street, she thinks the neighborhood today is just full of tourists, with even the surviving bars and coffeehouses now changing to serve people from out of town. She makes her way to Richard's apartment, which has an entrance that always makes her think of the word "squalid." The elevator doesn't work, so she takes the stairs. Clarissa knocks on Richard's door.

Richard greets Clarissa, still calling her "Mrs. D" (for Dalloway). Richard gets some help for his illness from new medicines, but he's unlucky compared to people like Evan, who contracted HIV later and benefited more from recent advances. This means Richard's mind is not as sharp as it used to be. Clarissa shows Richard all the **flowers** she has for his party, and he asks if all those flowers mean he's died.

Clarissa raises the shade on a window, since Richard doesn't have much light in his apartment. He has an old chair that smells and is falling apart, but he won't replace it. Clarissa asks Richard if his AIDS is still causing him to hallucinate. Richard says it's not at the moment. Earlier, though, he was seeing creatures that reminded him of black fire, both dark and bright, that were speaking to him in an ancient language. Clarissa suggests increasing his medication, but Richard says that just because he can't see the things doesn't mean they're gone.

Clarissa mentions seeing a movie star on the way over to Richard, and although he humors her, she knows he has no interest in famous people. She reminds him that his party starts at five o'clock. Richard gets confused and thinks that he remembers already being at the party, having fallen out of time. He doesn't look forward to having to pretend to be brave in front of everyone while he's sick. He thinks he's only getting the prize because he has AIDS, but Clarissa tries to reassure him.

Clarissa remembers the past as a wilder, less restrained time, and while there are elements of truth to that, it also contrasts sharply with the experience of Laura Brown. Although this novel only presents a day in the life for its three main characters, it covers events that span a much wider range of time, showing how even as Clarissa lives in the present, her thoughts wander to the past and future. This style of moving through time is one of the distinctive features of Mrs. Dalloway as well.



Clarissa's preference for the old bars and coffeehouses seems to reflect her longing for the past in general, which may also be related to her desire to turn back the clock on her relationship with Richard. Despite all of Richard's success as a writer, the details of his apartment suggest that he too may have nostalgia for the past.



Richard shows the toll of the HIV/AIDS epidemic, which continues to have consequences even after new treatments make it possible for people like Evan to live longer. Richard's joke about the flowers suggests that his condition makes him constantly aware of his own mortality.



Richard's hallucinations are a much stronger version of the way Clarissa seems to see the past when she walks around New York City. His old chair seems to reflect his own physical condition, but it also reflects his inability to let go of the past. The fact that Richard's hallucinations seem to speak in an ancient language further cements the idea that Richard lives in the past and that perhaps he even did so before his illness worsened.



Richard's confusion about time ties into the novel's larger theme about how a person can live in the present but experience time in a less linear way. His life shows how social norms change over time, with AIDS going from a stigma to a cause for honoring someone.



Clarissa goes over the guest list at the party, and Richard continues to be stressed. He doesn't want to have to speak to his publisher, Martin Campo, but Clarissa feels that Martin is a good man who spent his family fortune on publishing difficult books. She promises to stay by Richard's side at the party. Richard wonders if the party can just go on without him, but Clarissa insists that he show up. He feels embarrassed about what a big ego he used to have about his own work.

Richard says that his one regret is that he never got to write anything about his relationship with Clarissa. Clarissa reassures him that he's done so much that he shouldn't have any regrets. She promises to come back at 3:30 to help him get dressed before the party. As she goes, she kisses him on the cheek, so as not to spread any germs to him, since his immune system is so weak.

Clarissa stands up for Martin Campo because she herself tries to justify her current life by rationalizing that, like him, she has at least published some difficult books. Once again, Clarissa has complicated feelings toward Richard, as she simultaneously envies him for his award but pities him as she promises to help him get dressed before the party.



Richard's comment here about how he never had the chance to write about Clarissa may be a sign of his declining mental condition due to illness, since, in fact, many other characters believe that Richard's one novel he wrote is all about Clarissa—though this comment might also indicate that his novel wasn't actually about Clarissa, or at least that he didn't consciously intend to write it about her. Clarissa's inability to kiss Richard on the lips recalls her interaction with Walter. Here, it symbolizes how Richard's illness has now made it impossible for him and Clarissa to have a relationship.



CHAPTER 5: MRS. WOOLF

Virginia checks her clock and sees that about two hours have passed. She feels good about what she's written, although she knows she might not feel the same way about it tomorrow. She'd like to write for the whole day, but she fears that if she writes for more than a couple hours, her headaches will return. When she reaches her goal of 250 words, she reluctantly decides that's enough for the day.

Virginia goes down to the printing room, where Ralph and Leonard are working on page proofs. Leonard is in a bad mood due to the number of errors in the pages, but Ralph is more optimistic about their progress. Ralph is an assistant, and under Leonard, many assistants come and go. Virginia reassures Ralph that the book will be done soon enough, but she is really trying to reassure Leonard more than Ralph.

Completing 250 words in a day is a fairly small amount for a writer, suggesting how much Virginia's fear of headaches is slowing her down. Although Virginia's headaches seem to be related to writing, an earlier chapter revealed that the real reason she fears them is because she needs to remain in good health if she ever wants to get back to London—suggesting the headaches may be about more than just writing.



Virginia struggles to communicate with Ralph—at first, she doesn't want him to be discouraged, but as soon as she encourages him, she feels that she has gone too far. Their relationship shows how even though Virginia is in power as the employer, she nevertheless struggles to take agency in her household, where Leonard is the patriarch.



CHAPTER 6: MRS. BROWN

In London, Laura makes a **cake** with Richie. As she makes the cake, she feels like an artist or an architect creating something, perhaps even like Virginia writing *Mrs. Dalloway*. She guides Richie in what to do. When Richie pours the flour in and it all forms a big mound, he's afraid he did something wrong, but Laura reassures him. Laura begins to feel that maybe everything in her life is fine—that she will continue to be devoted to Dan and Richie and that she's all prepared for their second child.

Although the characters in the novel face many setbacks and disappointments, they also have moments of triumph. In this chapter, Laura seems to overcome all her doubts and finally prove that she can be the type of mother and wife that she wants to be. Unfortunately, the hours keep passing, and like the flowers that Clarissa Vaughan and Clarissa Dalloway each buy, Laura's moment of happiness can't last forever.



CHAPTER 7: MRS. WOOLF

Virginia walks up Mt. Ararat Road in Richmond, planning how and why her character Clarissa Dalloway will die by suicide. She imagines it will be due to a woman, one Clarissa knew and loved when she was young, before she decided to marry a man. She thinks about how women have to be more sensitive to small details, right down to the choice of a hat, and so she figures Clarissa will probably kill herself over something that seems very small on the outside.

Despite living with her husband and being surrounded by servants and guests, Virginia still feels isolated in many ways. Because she has no one that she could talk to about a subject like suicide, she instead uses her fiction as a way to make sense of the issue. Through her writing, Virginia manages to find the understanding she seeks, but much of it comes after her death, from strangers like Laura and Clarissa who read her novels.



Virginia reaches Hogarth House (her home, named after her publishing company Hogarth Press) and goes inside, where she finds Nelly downstairs in the kitchen, rolling out a pie crust. Nelly describes what she plans on serving for lunch, including yellow pears for the pudding, adding that she could do something different if Virginia wants something fancier. Virginia is disappointed by the pears but doesn't want people to think that she needs fancy things, so she goes along with it.

This passage shows the complicated power dynamics at play in Virginia's household. Although Virginia often defers to Leonard's authority, she herself has authority over servants like Nelly. As is often the case, Virginia struggles with her own desires, wanting the best food but also caring about what Nelly thinks of her, not wanting to appear too controlling or privileged.



Virginia reminds Nelly that Vanessa and her children are arriving in the afternoon for tea. She wants to give them China tea and sugared ginger, but Nelly says it would take a trip into London to get those things. Virginia replies that there's plenty of time for Nelly to get to London and back. Virginia feels maybe she is punishing Nelly for the pears and wishes she could be more skilled with servants, getting Nelly to not serve pears while still having Nelly love her. Virginia decides to make Clarissa Dalloway more skillful with servants.

Once again, Virginia's desires conflict with each other, as she wants to offer the best hospitality to Vanessa while still keeping Nelly happy. On top of this, a part of Virginia also resents Nelly for the pears in the previous passage. Like the characters that she writes about, Virginia's ordinary life has conflicts that are far more complex than they might initially seem on the surface.



CHAPTER 8: MRS. DALLOWAY

Clarissa gets home with her **flowers** and sees Sally in the hallway as she's on her way out to lunch with Oliver St. Ives, a movie star they both know. Sally asks if Clarissa needs help with anything, but Clarissa reassures her that she has the party under control. Clarissa thinks she feels something deathly in her hallway. Then she realizes it's worse than death—it's the idea that Richard is losing his whole identity to AIDS and won't be able to grow old with her.

Clarissa knows that she and Sally are wealthy by some standards, having two floors and a garden in the West Village, but she also feels that they aren't wealthy by New York standards. She tries to appreciate what she has and make peace with the idea that she's lucky regardless of whether the party goes well.

Clarissa thinks about Oliver St. Ives, who used to pretend to be a heterosexual hero in thrillers but who recently came out in a [Vanity Fair](#) article. Clarissa thinks about how, when Oliver St. Ives invited Sally to lunch, he probably didn't exclude Clarissa but just didn't think of her. Clarissa tries to reassure herself that her life is in no way a failure.

Clarissa thinks back to how Richard was in a relationship with her and Louis at the same time. Clarissa tried to have sex with Louis once, but it was clear they weren't meant for each other—instead, their main bond was that they both loved Richard. As much as Clarissa tells herself her current life is good, she can't help thinking of missed opportunities with Richard. While sex with Richard was not as satisfying as she hoped, but she still thinks back to the day when they kissed and went on a walk—when it seemed like her whole future would be full of happiness. She realizes now that the real happiness was in that moment of anticipation.

CHAPTER 9: MRS. BROWN

Laura is disappointed in how the **cake** she makes with Richie turns out, but she tries to love it even though she thinks it's a failure. She doesn't want it to distract her from taking care of the other items on her birthday to-do list. Just then, Kitty (Laura's friend and neighbor two doors down) shows up at the back door. Laura is excited but also nervous at Kitty's sudden appearance.

Once again, Clarissa's flowers symbolize how beauty is fleeting, with Clarissa regretting how she missed an opportunity to spend a life with Richard due to how quickly the time passed. Clarissa's fixation on the past and what she lost seems to prevent her from appreciating the relationship she has in the present with Sally.



For all her flaws, Clarissa is often self-aware. Like Virginia, Clarissa struggles with wanting the best and most beautiful things but also not wanting to get them at the expense of others who are less fortunate.



The changing career of Oliver St. Ives shows how ideas about gender and sexuality have changed, particularly since the time of Virginia and Laura. But Clarissa and Sally continue to have trouble communicating with each other, showing one way that the challenges of relationships haven't changed over time.



Unlike Virginia or Laura, Clarissa has had a chance to explore many of her sexual desires. And yet, despite Clarissa's constant nostalgia about her past with Richard, the reality of their relationship did little to satisfy her at the time. Clarissa is maybe less repressed than Virginia and Laura, but she still has a longing for something more, suggesting that there is something universal about this desire. As Clarissa realizes, perhaps what she is really nostalgic for is the anticipation at the start of a relationship—the sense that time is working in her favor rather than taking things away from her.



Laura's previous chapter seemed to end with a moment of triumph, but the challenge that each character in this novel faces is that each hour brings something new. Laura's change of mind about the cake may seem like a small matter, but Cunningham, like Woolf, tries to give dignity and importance to even everyday conflicts.



Kitty asks if she's interrupting anything, and Laura says of course not. Kitty is younger and seems more self-assured to Laura. Kitty notices the **cake** and says it's "cute," which Laura takes as evidence of her failure. Laura is slightly terrified of how much she values Kitty's friendship. Kitty seems more put-together than Laura, although Kitty's one flaw, in Laura's view, is her husband, Ray—Ray was prisoner of war in the Philippines, and now he looks prematurely middle aged and spits a lot when he talks.

Kitty takes some coffee and says she really likes it. She says she's considering switching from Maxwell House to Folgers for coffee, like Laura. The women chat for a bit, and then Kitty admits that she has to go to the hospital soon to have a growth on her uterus looked at—it might be why she hasn't been able to conceive a child with Ray. Laura is surprised to learn that Kitty is the reason they can't have a child, not Ray.

Laura hugs Kitty and tells her everything will be OK. Their lips touch, but they don't quite kiss. Kitty backs away first, but Laura worries that even though Kitty initiated the kiss, Laura is somehow the one who caused things to go "too far." Laura worries when she notices Richie watching them. She promises to feed Kitty's dog while Kitty is at the hospital. Kitty promises to call tomorrow with an update from the hospital. When Kitty leaves, Laura feels exhausted. Laura takes Richie into the living room, goes back to dump their **cake** into the garbage, then decides to make a new, better cake.

This passage closely follows Laura's viewpoint, making it difficult to tell how her perspective may be distorting things. For example, when Kitty calls the cake "cute," it may in fact be a compliment, but Laura's doubts from the previous passage have primed her to interpret the comment negatively. Similarly, although Laura dislikes Ray, the main flaw she dislikes about him is how he spits too much, suggesting that perhaps Laura only knows Ray on a superficial level.



Maxwell House and Folgers are both cheap coffee brands. Kitty's comment shows how in late-1940s suburban culture, brands are a part of person's identity, almost like rooting for a sports team. But Cunningham doesn't depict Kitty as superficial—the growth on her uterus suggests that beneath her exterior as a successful housewife there is hidden pain.



Like Virginia and like the character Mrs. Dalloway, Laura has desires that she can't act on, partly due to the society she lives in and partly due to her own sense of shame. Laura's guilt about kissing Kitty is not just about the stigmas around homosexuality at the time but also about her feeling that she should be content with her family and repress any desire for more. Ultimately, Laura's decision to re-make the cake is not just about insecurity, but also a way for her to punish herself for momentarily dreaming of something more than her role as a mother and housewife.



CHAPTER 10: MRS. WOOLF

Virginia is reading book proofs with Leonard and Ralph when suddenly, they notice that Vanessa has arrived early with her kids. Leonard doesn't want to interrupt his work, but Virginia promises to keep her occupied. Virginia goes up to greet Vanessa and jokes that she's happy to see her but would have been even happier to see her later, at the time she originally promised. Vanessa just laughs and says they finished their business in London early.

Vanessa's three children (Julian, Quentin, and Angelica) are out in the yard, looking at a bird they found that seems to be sick. They want to bring it inside, but Vanessa warns that it's wild and would probably prefer to die outside. They suggest instead having an outdoor funeral for it. Virginia joins them, marveling at their enthusiasm, particularly Angelica's.

Virginia envies Vanessa's seeming freedom (including the ability to go to London when she wants), and this dynamic resembles Laura and Kitty. Virginia's distress about Vanessa's early arrival hints at how Virginia is obsessed with time, and how she wants to control it in the small ways that she can.



The prologue has already revealed that Virginia herself will die by suicide, and this passage where she observes how enthusiastically Vanessa's children hold the bird funeral is an early sign of how Virginia herself is thinking about death.



After the bird funeral, Virginia tells Vanessa that she can't make tea until Nelly returns from London. Everyone goes inside, but Virginia lingers by the dead bird in a circle of roses. She thinks of how she wouldn't mind being in the bird's place. She decides that her character Clarissa won't be "the bride of death" after all, but rather "the bed in which the bride is laid."

In the final novel, Clarissa Dalloway does not in fact kill herself. Although Mrs. Dalloway is a flawed character, this novel suggests that in many ways, she is also an ideal for Virginia, living in London and able to overcome any potential suicidal thoughts.



CHAPTER 11: MRS. DALLOWAY

Clarissa fills a **flower** vase with yellow roses. She is surprised when Louis buzzes the intercom at her apartment. She feels he's the only New Yorker she knows who would show up without calling first. It's been about five years since Clarissa last saw Louis, and she's a little nervous. He looks the same as he has ever since he lost his bulk and strength about two decades ago. They greet each other happily, and Louis tears up.

Louis hasn't heard about Richard's prize, but Clarissa said he should come and that Richard will be happy to see him. Even though Richard lived with Louis for much of his life, he spent his last years of health writing about a woman in a townhouse in Manhattan, with only a brief appearance from a character who resembles Louis.

Louis walks into the apartment and sees that most of the decorating seems to be influenced by Sally's taste. He thinks that even though Clarissa definitely looks older, she still has some glamor to her. Clarissa says she can't believe that Louis hasn't been back to New York in five years. In reality, Louis has been back—he just never looked her up.

Clarissa warns Louis that Richard isn't the same as he used to be due to his AIDS. They talk about Richard's one novel. Louis feels Richard barely even tried to hide that he was writing about Clarissa, but Clarissa feels that the character is just Richard's fantasy of a woman who resembles her. The novel is over 900 pages of almost nothing happening, until suddenly the character kills herself.

Yellow roses traditionally symbolize friendship, and in this case, they stand as a reminder that Richard is just Clarissa's friend and not her romantic partner (who might receive red roses instead). Once again, a chapter echoes the previous one, with Louis's unexpected arrival mirroring how Vanessa arrived early at Virginia's place.



This passage reveals that for all Richard's success, he is just like Clarissa in the way that he longs for the past and all the possibilities it promises. Like many characters in the novel, he was in a relationship that seemed ideal on paper, but he couldn't let go of his longing for something more.



The narration in the novel not only jumps through time but also from character to character, on rare occasions following the thoughts of minor characters like Louis. This type of shifting perspective also appeared in several of Woolf's works, and it helps show the limitations of the protagonists' subjective views of the world by providing a different viewpoint.



Although Richard received acclaim for his writing, this passage questions how talented he truly was. Most of Woolf's novels (including Mrs. Dalloway) are fairly short, like The Hours itself, standing in stark contrast to Richard's 900-page epic. This portion of the narrative seems to suggest that even with nearly a 1,000 pages, Richard couldn't understand Clarissa's life as well as Virginia Woolf understood her own Clarissa, even though Woolf wrote only a couple hundred pages.



Clarissa tells Louis that as much as Richard has changed, he still holds on to some part of his old self. They each regret how they treated each other in the past. For a moment, Clarissa almost thinks it seems like she and Louis are about to have sex, but then Louis mentions that he has fallen in love with a former student named Hunter Craydon (who is at least the fourth of his students that he's fallen in love with). But in fact, secretly Louis knows that his relationship with Hunter is just an affair.

Thinking about love and the past, Louis gets emotional and starts to cry. Just then, Clarissa's daughter Julia arrives at the apartment. Louis hasn't seen Julia in five years and almost gets emotional again over how grown up she looks. At last, Louis says he has to go—he's only in the city for a couple more days, but eventually, he's moving back permanently. He promises to make it to Richard's party.

As Louis leaves, he thinks back on his past and how, when he was 28 and on a trip with Richard to Rome, he got upset with Richard after a letter from Clarissa to Richard made Louis feel like Richard was more interested in her than in him. He remembers how freeing it felt to take a train to Madrid and leave Richard behind, at least temporarily.

Like Richard and Clarissa, Louis also holds on to nostalgia for the past, and for him, this takes the form of relationships with much younger students. Louis calls these relationships love even when he knows they're not, since—like Clarissa—he is always searching for that invigorating feeling that comes in the beginning of a relationship.



In contrast to the students who help Louis maintain the illusion that he's still young, Julia has the opposite effect by providing clear evidence of how much things can change in five years. Perhaps because the students are not enough to stop Louis's fear of aging, he wants to go back to New York City (where he went to college) to try to recapture his youth in a different way.



Richard's obsession with the past prevented him from having a full relationship with Louis. And yet, in spite of all Louis's frustrations with Richard, it was Richard who decided to leave for good. In Madrid, Louis wanted to be rid of Richard, but when he finally gets his wish years later, he realizes he still feels unsatisfied.



CHAPTER 12: MRS. BROWN

Laura drops Richie off with her neighbor Mrs. Latch, claiming she has to run an errand. In reality, she is making a new **cake**. After she finishes the cake and completes some other tasks for the day, she leaves the house, bringing along her copy of *Mrs. Dalloway*. The new cake she made looks much more elegant. She thinks about when her lips touched Kitty's and realizes that she desires Kitty, although she also still desires Dan.

Even though the second **cake** is better, Laura still regrets its imperfections. She wants to go somewhere to read but can't find a place, since in most places she'll either have to pay money, be bothered, or be unsafe. The problem with public places like a library or a park is they feel too public for her. At last, she decides to pay for a hotel room.

Laura goes first to a cheap motel, then decides that it might be too sleazy, and she wouldn't know how to act. She goes instead to a nicer hotel for tourists and businessmen. She gets a double room, lying and saying her husband will be coming in an hour or so. She pays up front, then heads to her room.

Laura's decision to drop off Richie seems to be because she doesn't want him to accidentally witness anything else, like when she just kissed Kitty. The new cake represents a chance for Laura to start over, creating something pristine to make up for the guilt she feels about desiring Kitty.



Laura's house is deserted, and yet she still feels the need to escape it, suggesting that her household chores have imprisoned her. Although Laura can be anxious, this passage suggests that Laura isn't just imagining dangers and that, in fact, suburban life lacks places where a woman can go to have some privacy.



This whole chapter strongly recalls Virginia Woolf's essay "A Room of One's Own." The essay explores a range of feminist themes but ultimately centers on the idea that for a woman to pursue a creative activity like writing, she needs a private place for herself.



When Laura gets to the room, it's clean, but she can tell it's been used a lot. She begins reading *Mrs. Dalloway*, feeling she has finally left her life behind and is closer to Virginia Woolf than she's ever felt before. She reads part of the book that makes her realize that a person can choose to die and that it's possible—and maybe even probable—that someone ended their life in her hotel room. Laura says “I would never” out loud to herself, patting her pregnant belly. Nevertheless, Laura imagines Virginia stepping into the river with pockets full of rocks and thinks of how easy that would be to do.

Woolf's essay “A Room of One's Own” suggested that a woman needs freedom from interruptions in order to write well. In this passage, the privacy of Laura's hotel room brings her closer to Woolf than she's ever felt before. But while this feeling thrills Laura at first, it also has darker implications, since to be like Virginia Woolf is also to struggle with suicidal feelings. Once again, a character learns that getting what she desired (in Laura's case, privacy) might not be quite what she expected.



CHAPTER 13: MRS. WOOLF

Virginia apologizes for not having gifts for Vanessa's children. All the while, she is thinking about her novel and decides that Clarissa won't kill herself—that someone else has to kill themselves, someone intelligent and tragic. Just then, Nelly gets back from London with the China tea and candied ginger, looking both triumphant and angry. Virginia is nevertheless happy. When Nelly isn't looking, Virginia kisses Vanessa, feeling like she's getting away with something secret.

Virginia's thoughts suggest that Mrs. Dalloway's plot is getting closer to its final form (where the character Septimus, who is intelligent but scarred by World War I, kills himself). Clarissa and Laura have each had kisses that resulted in complicated emotions, and now Virginia herself has one. While it is possible to read Virginia as having incestuous feelings in this scene, what Virginia really seems to long for is the freedom to be intimate. Virginia feels the pressure to live up to her role as the lady of the house whenever Nelly is watching, and this prevents her from showing intimacy.



CHAPTER 14: MRS. DALLOWAY

Julia remarks how strange Louis is. Clarissa agrees and hopes he won't ruin Richard's party. Clarissa thinks Julia is very beautiful even though she wears six rings on her left hand and even has a nose ring but never wears the ring Clarissa got her for the 18th birthday.

Each of the three protagonists of the novel represents a different generation of women, and Julia represents the start of yet another generation. Clarissa interprets Julia's refusal to wear her birthday ring as a sign that Julia is rejecting her, but in fact, Julia's superficial differences from Clarissa don't stop the two of them from having a fairly close relationship. Just as Richard misinterprets Clarissa, Clarissa misinterprets Julia.



Julia is about to go shopping with her friend Mary Krull and has come by to pick up her backpack. In fact, Mary is outside smoking a cigarette. Clarissa suggests that maybe Mary can come in and say hello when she's done. Julia looks embarrassed or perhaps defiant and says she could go get Mary, but Clarissa changes her mind and says there's no need. Julia assures her mother that Mary is friendly and goes to get her.

Although Clarissa sees Julia as defiant, in fact, this scene shows that Julia is determined to do whatever it takes to get Clarissa's approval. This passage is yet another one that explores everyday conflict, showing how a simple conversation can reveal volumes about the dynamic between Julia and Clarissa, including how each wants to please the other without always understanding what the other actually wants.



Mary is stern, with a shaved head. She's wearing a tank top and looks like she's probably older than 40. She and Clarissa greet each other politely. Julia says they're shopping because Mary needs new boots. Clarissa thinks that with Mary, Julia seems like a 1950s housewife. Clarissa tells Julia to take good care of Mary, while Mary secretly thinks about how Clarissa is deluded and if anyone ever decides to "round up the deviants," Clarissa will be right there next to Mary. Clarissa also secretly thinks Mary is a fraud for being just as aggressive and egotistical as most men.

Julia and Mary get ready to go, and Clarissa reminds Mary to be at Richard's party at five o'clock. As Mary leaves, she thinks about how much she desires Julia but how Julia seems to be straight and probably won't ever love her romantically.

Despite their different physical appearances, Mary and Clarissa are united in their belief that the other one is behind the times. Like Richard, Mary believes that queer relationships must leave behind the limits and conventions of heterosexual relationships. Clarissa herself can perhaps see the appeal of this longing for more, but she also wants to be accepted and understood, which is perhaps why her relationship with Sally is not so different from the heterosexual marriages in the novel.



This passage humorously shows that, for all of Clarissa's fears that Mary is brainwashing Julia, the relationship seems to be platonic, with Julia taking charge. Mary is yet another character with more going on beneath the surface than it initially seems.



CHAPTER 15: MRS. WOOLF

Vanessa has left Virginia's house. As Nelly prepares dinner, she's in a surprisingly good mood. Leonard is writing in the study while Virginia looks out the parlor window and watches it get dark. She's afraid that she feels a headache coming on but realizes it's just the memory of a headache. She thinks of the dead bird in the yard and then goes out to look at it.

Virginia goes out the gate and starts heading toward the center of Richmond, not knowing what she'll do when she gets there. She gets there and overhears conversations of people talking, but they just make her feel more alone. She heads toward the rail station and considers taking a spontaneous trip to London.

When Virginia steps inside the Richmond train station, she sees that it will be almost 25 minutes until the next train to London. She wonders what to do, fearing what will happen if she gets ill again while away. She's over 40 and feels her life is slipping away from her. She buys a ticket and waits at the station for a while, but eventually she decides to walk out toward Kew Road, which will give her just enough time to get back.

Although this passage initially seems to paint a blissful scene, the darkening sky, Virginia's fear of a headache, and the dead bird show the turmoil beneath the peaceful scene. This passage is the opposite of the hopeful anticipation that many characters long for—it conveys instead the oppressive feeling that something bad is on the horizon.



Like Laura, Virginia begins to feel a sense of freedom and possibility as soon as she gets out of the house, suggesting the heavy burden of household responsibilities. Still, Virginia continues to face disappointment—despite her desire for independence, she also seeks intimacy and connection, and the strangers she hears talking remind her of what she doesn't have.



Once again, Virginia alternates between hope and dread, as the train offers her the possibility to escape but also more waiting and potential disappointment. Virginia's inability to wait at the station shows her impatience, which is related to her fear that her life is passing so quickly.



As Virginia is walking, she happens to see Leonard. She wonders if she can get away, but he sees her. He asks what she's doing, since it seems like she just disappeared. Virginia accuses Leonard of acting strange himself. Leonard says they must get back in time for dinner so that Nelly doesn't get angry.

In the home, Leonard often controls Virginia in subtle ways, and here, he foils Virginia's whole escape plan simply by happening to go for a walk in the same area. Once again, Virginia and Leonard have a seemingly innocuous conversation that reveals a lot about their marriage and about the more powerful status of men compared to women in this time period.



Virginia says it's about time for them to move back to London. Leonard isn't sure but says they can discuss it over dinner. They both agree that they wish they could be happy with a quiet life, but they can't. Virginia keeps her train ticket in her bag but plans to never tell Leonard about it.

Although Virginia fears Leonard's authority and how he can keep her trapped in Richmond, this passage reveals that he is yet another character with more going on beneath the surface—he too struggles to feel satisfied with his life, even though he knows he has a lot to be thankful for. Virginia's unused train ticket represents all the other choices she could have made in her life but didn't.



CHAPTER 16: MRS. DALLOWAY

Oliver St. Ives offers Sally more coffee. His eager assistant pours her some. They're talking about a potential future film that Oliver is excited about, though Sally isn't sure it could ever get made. Oliver assures her that Walter Hardy, a novelist who is also at the lunch with them, can help get it made.

This chapter explores the character of Sally, who up until this point has mostly only appeared at a distance as a supportive partner. It soon becomes clear that Clarissa's view of Sally is limited, and as much as Clarissa fears that Sally is a more sophisticated person who hangs out with movie stars, Sally herself doesn't seem to feel comfortable in this environment.



Oliver describes how the film will be a conventional thriller with a gay man for the hero, but he can't be tortured about his sexuality or have HIV. Oliver notices that Sally still doesn't seem convinced by the pitch. She protests that she doesn't even have any connections to Hollywood, but he says she probably knows the industry better than many people who do have connections. Oliver makes plans to discuss the film in more detail with Walter later. Sally realizes that the two of them never really needed her.

Oliver's desire for acceptance, including the ability to play a gay character who is similar to a heterosexual character, resembles Sally's own attempts to make her partnership with Clarissa resemble a heterosexual marriage. But Sally remains skeptical that Oliver's plan can work, hinting at the problems with her relationship with Clarissa.



After lunch, Sally and Walter stand on a street corner. Walter comments that he'll see Sally later that evening at five o'clock, and Sally wonders who invited him to the party. Walter goes into a store that sells formal shirts to buy a present for his boyfriend, Evan, and Sally ends up following him. Sally thinks about how Evan has been sick for a while. At one point he seemed likely to die, but now he looks more likely to live. She wonders if Walter has mixed feelings.

Sally's thoughts about Walter and Evan seem to be related to her own difficulties in her relationship with Clarissa, which Sally avoids thinking about openly. Evan's situation once again captures this pivotal moment in the HIV/AIDS epidemic when effective treatments first became widespread.



Sally watches Walter spend \$400 on a shirt. Sally thinks about how many of her own gifts seem to fall short, although Clarissa never admits it. Sally and Walter leave the store and part ways. Sally wishes she could bring back a gift for Clarissa and truly tell her how much she means to her—although Sally and Clarissa freely say, “I love you,” she wants to say something less ordinary.

Clarissa frets about Julia not wearing the ring she gave her, and yet Clarissa herself struggles to appreciate Sally's gifts. Sally's thoughts here reveal the challenges of a relationship and how even traditional gestures like gift-giving or saying “I love you” are not enough to guarantee intimacy.



Sally takes the subway downtown. She still wants a gift for Clarissa, so she decides to stop at a Korean market and buy some **flowers**—roses. When Sally gets back to the apartment, she can tell from Clarissa's voice that something is wrong. Sally asks what's wrong, and Clarissa mentions Louis's recent visit and Julia's visit with Mary. Clarissa notices that Sally bought roses, and they both laugh when they realize that it's like an O. Henry story since Clarissa just bought roses too.

O. Henry was a short story writer who is perhaps best known for “Gift of the Magi,” where a man sells his watch to buy his wife a set of combs, and the woman sells her hair to buy him a watch chain. In a similar vein to that story, Sally gives Clarissa the one thing she needs least at the moment—more roses—and yet, the gesture ends up revealing that their relationship might still be deep after all, with the roses showing how the two of them appreciate the same things.



CHAPTER 17: MRS. BROWN

Laura gets back from her hotel room near six o'clock, a little later than she planned, thinking about the characters in *Mrs. Dalloway* on the drive home. Even as she pulls into Mrs. Latch's driveway, Laura continues to feel disconnected from her life. She is also still thinking about death. Laura feels like she's hiding a secret, like an affair, even though she didn't do anything particularly harmful.

Laura's suicidal feelings hint at how unsatisfying her lifestyle as a suburban housewife is. Laura hoped that escaping her house would offer a sense of release, but being alone just made her suicidal feelings stronger. Her situation captures how suburban life can be isolating and alienating—in both Laura's time period and Virginia's.



Laura apologizes to Mrs. Latch for being late, but Mrs. Latch says it's no problem. Richie starts to cry when Laura comes over, but Mrs. Latch says he's just glad to see her. Laura is a little embarrassed of how often Richie cries because she figures it makes other people assume that she is overprotective.

Like Dan, Mrs. Latch seems understanding of Laura's shortcomings (like when she shows up late), but Laura puts the pressure on herself to succeed as a mother.



Laura takes Richie home, saying they should have just enough time to get everything ready before Dan comes back. All of a sudden, Laura hears Richie say “I love you” in a tone of voice that concerns her because it seems desperate. She wonders if he's thinking about her with Kitty or if he knows she did something unusual while she was away. She reassures Richie that she loves him and that they'll have a nice party for Dan with a nice **cake** that evening.

Despite his young age, Richie seems to sense that something is the matter with Laura. Richie saying “I love you” and really meaning it is a reversal of the previous chapter, where “I love you” was just a commonplace saying between Clarissa and Sally. Laura imagines that Richie sees so much that he can practically read her mind, suggesting how the pressure of being a mother and wife makes her feel like she is always being watched.



CHAPTER 18: MRS. DALLOWAY

Clarissa goes to help Richard get ready for his party, but when she knocks and no one answers, she gets nervous. She unlocks the door and goes in. When she calls, Richard answers. He's in a bathrobe sitting on the sill of an open fifth-story window, with one leg in the apartment and one outside. He sounds calm and acts casual, but Clarissa rushes over, terrified.

Richard says that after taking Xanax and Ritalin together, he felt like he needed more air and light, so he opened all the windows and put his leg outside. He worries that he can't make it to the party. Clarissa begs him to bring his leg in, but Richard doesn't move. Clarissa tells him he doesn't have to worry about the party or the ceremony, but Richard says that even if he skips those, he'll still have to deal with "the hours," which keep coming one after the other.

Clarissa tells Richard he still has good days to look forward too, but Richard says that isn't really true anymore. He tells Clarissa to call his mother, since his mother lives alone. Richard then asks Clarissa to tell him a story about the most ordinary thing she can think of. Clarissa starts telling a very short story about buying **flowers** that morning.

Richard recalls being 19 and in love with both Clarissa and Louis. He starts talking about how he failed at life. Clarissa tells him again not to worry about the party. Calling her "Mrs. Dalloway," Richard says Clarissa has been good to her and that he loves her. He thinks the two of them were as happy as any two people could be. Then he slides out the window.

After several characters have experienced suicidal thoughts in the novel, this is the first event that seems to hint at suicidal action (Richard hallway out the window). In spite of the potentially dire situation, the tone of this passage is understated, reflecting Richard's disconnected state of mind. Earlier, Laura imagined suicide being as simple as checking in to a hotel, and this passage has a similarly casual tone.



While new drugs have managed to save the life of people like Evan, Richard shows the darker side of medical progress and how some drugs can cause people to lose track of reality if taken incorrectly. As Richard reveals in his words about "the hours," every moment seems to bring him some sort of suffering to endure, showing the toll of mental health struggles.



Richard faces the same problem as Clarissa, Virginia, and several other characters in the novel: As he gets older, his life becomes less about anticipating the future, more about regretting the past. When Richard asks to hear an ordinary story to comfort him, Clarissa tells a story that begins the same way as Mrs. Dalloway: with buying flowers. This passage yet again shows the significance of ordinary life, which seems to comfort Richard in his darkest moment.



*By calling Clarissa "Mrs. Dalloway," Richard puts himself in the role of Mrs. Dalloway's friend Septimus, who kills himself near the end of that novel. Septimus was never the same after fighting in World War I, and Richard's experience with the HIV/AIDs epidemic has had a similarly traumatic effect on him. Richard's final words to Clarissa quote part of the real Woolf's final note to Leonard (which is quoted in the Prologue of *The Hours*). Richard bookends his relationship with Clarissa, which began with the nickname "Mrs. Dalloway" and now has ended with a different reference to Woolf.*



Clarissa screams and goes to the window. She sees Richard still falling, with his robe flapping in the wind and imagines maybe somehow it will be OK. But when he hits the ground, he doesn't get up. She rushes down the stairs to find where Richard fell and knows immediately that he's dead. She pulls back part of his robe to see his head, then screams at what she sees.

Richard's body in the air, with his robe flapping, resembles Virginia's body in the water, with her coat floating around her. Each image seems to suggest how death provides them with a fleeting moment of freedom, but in each case, this triumphant moment quickly turns into something much grimmer (Virginia's body stuck at the bottom, Richard lying still on the pavement).



Clarissa stays by the body, resting her head against Richard's back. She thinks of all the things she would say to him if she could. She wants to tell him she loves him to and to ask forgiveness for not kissing him on the lips, since she was only trying to do it for his own health.

Clarissa initially feared that kissing Richard on the lips would harm his health, but now she fears that she may have played some role in his death by not kissing him on the lips and withholding that intimacy. This moment once again captures how the passage of time inevitably leads to certain regrets.



CHAPTER 19: MRS. BROWN

Dan blows out his birthday cake, and although Laura applauds and says, "Happy birthday," she is secretly angry at him for accidentally spitting on the **cake**. But when Dan puts his arm around her, she remembers how good he can be. Laura asks Richie if he made a wish too. Richie nods, even though he didn't think of the idea—his wish, similar to Dan's, is for things to stay the way they are.

Earlier, Laura justified to herself that Dan was a better husband than Kitty's husband, Ray, because Ray spits too much when he talks. When Dan spits on the cake that Laura spent so much time worrying about, it not only shows that Dan doesn't understand Laura's hard work, but it also shows Laura that there might not be anything special about Dan compared to Ray after all.



Dan asks Richie to help him cut the cake. Laura goes to get dessert plates and thinks about her life compared to Kitty in the hospital. When she puts plates and forks on the table, she feels as if she has somehow miraculously succeeded at the last minute in her plans for the day. Laura watches Dan help Richie cut the cake. Laura imagines good will prevail in the world and even Kitty will get better soon. She savors the moment even as she feels like it's a page in a book about to turn. She watches a smiling Richie lick icing off a candle and make another wish.

Laura is clearly disappointed by Dan's reaction to the cake, but she tries to cope with it by focusing on anticipation for the future, as many other characters in the novel do. Richie embodies Laura's hope for a better world—he is young and innocent, able to live in the moment without dreading the future. Undercutting the hopeful nature of this scene is the fact that Richie grows up into Richard, who is unable to escape the same feelings of hopelessness that his mother experiences and who ultimately dies by suicide.



CHAPTER 20: MRS. WOOLF

Virginia is having difficulty concentrating on the books she's reading, so she tries to reassure herself by thinking of how at dinner, she managed to convince Leonard to move back to London. She makes promises to finish writing her current book and write many more.

Like Laura in the last chapter, Virginia also experiences a moment of triumph, made bittersweet by the knowledge that, as the prologue reveals, she'll eventually die by suicide. Still, Virginia succeeds in her goal of finishing her book and writing many more. This passage shows how, in fact, dread and anticipation related to the passage of time are not always opposites and can exist alongside each other.



Suddenly, Virginia thinks of kissing Vanessa. She thinks the kiss was innocent in some ways but also mysterious and not innocent in other ways, which is why they hid it from Nelly. Leonard gets up from his own chair and asks if Virginia is going to bed. She says she's not tired yet, but Leonard says he'd like to see her in bed within a half hour. Virginia agrees. She thinks about how in her book, she will make it so that Clarissa Dalloway has loved a woman and even kissed a woman, but just once. Clarissa will get to go on living her life and enjoying London while some "deranged poet" will die in the novel instead.

Even now, in her moment of contentment, Virginia can't help wanting more and thinking of something that disturbs her happiness. Leonard's seemingly innocuous command for Virginia to come to bed in half an hour reveals a lot about why Virginia feels trapped in her current relationship—and why she thinks a relationship with a woman might be better. Virginia's story ends with her deciding that her character Mrs. Dalloway should exist in a state of stasis, always enjoying her life in London. And so, fiction offers a way to achieve what isn't possible in real life.



CHAPTER 21: MRS. BROWN

Laura finishes brushing her teeth, thinking of Richie already in bed and Dan waiting for her. She won't be able to read because Dan will want to have sex. She looks at a nearly full bottle of sleeping pills in the bathroom, which she can't use because she's pregnant. She thinks about how taking all the pills would be as simple as checking into a hotel room.

This passage shows that the actions of everyday life can hide despair. When Laura thinks she can't use the sleeping pills because she's pregnant, her thoughts have a double meaning, suggesting that, while she can't use sleeping pills for their prescribed use while pregnant, she also can't use them as a means of suicide because she feels a sense of obligation to her future child.



Laura closes the cabinet and heads into her bedroom. Dan says he had a great birthday and invites her to bed. Laura says she's coming, but she doesn't move, feeling like a ghost observing things. Dan invites her to bed again. In the distance, she hears a dog bark.

Like Leonard's command for Virginia to come to bed, Dan's invitation to Laura seems innocent but reveals the large power imbalance in their marriage. This timeline ends with the image of a barking dog, suggesting that Laura has realized that her current role as a wife and mother requires her to be as obedient as a dog.



CHAPTER 22: MRS. DALLOWAY

Clarissa and Sally carefully lead Laura (who is now elderly) down the hallway to their apartment. Julia has put away the food for Richard's party, but the **flowers** are still in the vase. Clarissa introduces Julia to Laura. Julia offers her condolences. Julia tells them she managed to reach almost everyone on the guest list to tell them not to come, but a few showed up, including Louis, and she had to break the news of Richard's death.

The final chapter of the book brings together the different timelines, showing three different generations of women (Laura, Clarissa and Sally, and Julia) that came after Woolf. On the one hand, they seem to be caught in a cycle, with Julia just beginning to learn about the grief that has become a major part of the older women's lives. At the same time, this chapter also begins with optimism, showing how in spite of all her troubles, Laura managed to survive to old age.



It's now 10 minutes past midnight. Clarissa tells Laura there's a bed ready for her when she wants it. Clarissa says Richard was wonderful, and Laura agrees, saying he was also a good writer. Clarissa senses that Laura knows that Richard's novel was inspired by Clarissa. Laura asks if Clarissa ever edited Richard's writing, but she says an editor needs some objectivity and that she was too close to Richard.

Clarissa says she tried to take care of Richard the best she could. Laura says she did too, but she wishes she could have done better. Laura attempted suicide at one point and fled her family, but has somehow outlasted both Dan, who died of cancer, and her daughter, who was killed by a drunk driver.

Clarissa wonders how Richard felt as he jumped out the window. She wonders what it felt like to hit the ground and assumes there couldn't have been much pain—and might have even been some pleasure. Sally and Julia have decided to eat some of the party food so it won't go to waste. Clarissa thinks the food looks pristine and permanent, even though she knows how perishable it really is. Sally says that everyone should eat and go to bed.

Clarissa thinks about how after she and everyone else goes to bed, it will truly feel like Richard has left the world. She wonders if any of Richard's writing will survive, imagining that it's possible people in the future might want to read him but that most books, even good ones, are more likely to vanish. She thinks about how most people lead lives full of difficulty with only "an hour here or there" when everything seems to be perfect.

Julia asks if she should make a plate for Laura, but Clarissa says she'll see to Laura. Laura gives a weak smile, and Clarissa has no idea what Laura could be thinking. Clarissa is no longer Mrs. Dalloway because Richard isn't around anymore to call her that. She has yet another hour in front of her to face. She invites Laura into the kitchen, saying everything's ready.

Clarissa and Laura romanticize Richard after his death, with each ignoring the more difficult aspects of their relationship with him. Once again, however, this sad moment also offers the potential for optimism, showing how for all Richard's flaws and for all that his disease diminished him, the people who loved him still focus on his positive qualities after his death.



This passage once again combines despair and optimism, showing how the passage of time can take away innocent people like Laura's daughter but also how it can help people like Laura become resilient and survive the darkest moments of their lives.



The pristine food for Richard's party, like the flowers, symbolizes how fleeting beauty can be. Clarissa has an abundance of good food, but she probably won't be able to use it all before it spoils. While Clarissa continues to think about the past and the future, Sally and Julia find a way to live in the present by eating the food while it's still good.



Books seem to represent a type of permanent knowledge that passes from generation to generation, but as Clarissa notes, enduring books like Mrs. Dalloway are the exception more than the rule. Clarissa envied Richard's fame as a writer (particularly since the books from her own publishing house have been struggling), but now that she sees how quickly his fame might disappear, she has to confront the idea that even Richard may one day be forgotten by time and become irrelevant.



Despite all of Clarissa's fears and anxieties in this chapter, the novel ultimately ends with Clarissa accepting that her only choice is to live in the present and try to make the best of it. Rather than focusing on the grim consequences of Richard's death, Clarissa tries to find a sense of anticipation around the fact that, without Richard around to call her Mrs. Dalloway anymore, Clarissa has the freedom to attempt to build a new version of herself.





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